

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 1

1. Prehistory and Indologists.....	
2. Indus Valley Civilisation (3300-1300 BCE).....	6
3. Vedic Period (1500-600 BC).....	11
4. Mahajanapadas (600 – 321 BCE).....	15
5. Buddhism.....	19
6. Jainism.....	32
7. Mauryas (321 – 185 BCE) and Post Mauryas (200 – 300 CE).....	38
8. Guptas, Post Guptas and Harsha.....	51
9. The Sangam Age.....	57
10. Medieval Regional Kingdoms and Administration.....	60
11. Bhakti and Sufi Movement.....	76
12. Delhi Sultanate.....	81
13. Hoysalas, Vijaynagara, Bahmani and Deccan Sultanate Empire.....	89
14. Mughals and Post Mughals.....	98
15. Marathas.....	

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History -- Part 2

Timeline of Ancient and Medieval History

Time North/Central India Deccan & West India South India

6th BCE

Mahajanapadas,

Magadha: Haryanka

(Bimbisara,

Ajatashatru)

Northwest:

Achaemenid

Persian Empire

(Cyrus)

Early Sangam

Kingdoms:

Pandya, Chera,

Chola

5th BCE Magadha: Haryanka

(Ajatashatru)

Achaemenid

Persian Empire

(Darius,

Xerxes)

Pandya, Chera,

Chola

4th BCE

Magadha: Nanda and

Alexander invasion

(327 BCE to 325

BCE)

Maurya

(founded by

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History -- Part 3

9th CE

Tripartite Struggle:

Gurjara-Pratihara

(Mihira Bhoja,

836–885 CE), Pala

Rashtrakuta

(peak)

Pallava (decline);

Rise of Chola

(850 CE)

Pandya

10th CE Pratihara (decline)

Regional Rise:

Gahadavala,

Chandella,

Paramara

Rise of

Chalukyas of

Kalyani, Yadava

Rashtrakuta

(decline)

Chola

(expansion) Pandya

11th CE

Pratiharas(Decline)

Invasions: Mahmud

of Ghazni

Gahadavala,

Chandella,

Paramara

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 4

1

Prehistory and Indologists

The period before the development of script is called the pre-historic times. It is also referred to as the Stone Age. India experienced

an early development of cultures and civilisations. Since the Old Stone Age, several groups in India had migrated multiple times and

made cultural adaptations to diverse eco-zones. The earliest age in history is called Old Stone Age or Palaeolithic.

1

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following information: [2024]

Archaeological Site:: State:: Description

1. Chandraketugarh: Odisha: Trading Port town
2. Inamgaon: Maharashtra: Chalcolithic site
3. Mangadu: Kerala: Megalithic site
4. Salihundam: Andhra Pradesh: Rockcut cave shrines

In which of the above rows is the given information correctly matched?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 3 and 4
- (d) 1 and 4

2. Consider the following pairs: [2021]

Historical place: Well known for

1. Burzahom: Rock cut shrines
2. Chandraketugarh: Terracotta art
3. Ganeshwar: Copper artefacts

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 2 and 3

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 5

2

Paleolithic Period (~5,00,000 BCE – 10,000 BCE)

y About: Earliest phase in human history (Old Stone Age); First tools in India identified at Pallavaram (1863) by Robert

Bruce Foote

y Lifestyle: Habitation – open areas, caves, rock shelters; Food – hunting and gathering

y Human Evolution: Homo habilis (Earliest tool-maker) – Homo erectus (Used fire and advanced tools) – Homo sapiens

sapiens (Developed art and cave paintings)

y Two Tool Cultures:

– Acheulian Culture (named after Saint-Acheul site in France) – Used bifacial flaking on quartzite, handaxes and

cleavers; found in Africa, Europe, Middle East, Central & South India; absent in Western Ghats, coastal & North East

India.

– Soanian Culture (In present-day Pakistan; named after the Soan River valley) – Used choppers and chopping

tools; Confined to north-western region; limited archaeological evidence

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 6

3

Mesolithic Period (10,000 – 6000 BCE)

y About: Transitional phase – hunting-gathering (Palaeolithic) – food production (Neolithic); adaptation to post-Ice Age

climatic changes (End of Ice Age – warmer conditions – Human groups more mobile)

y Lifestyle: Temporary huts & rock shelters; hunting – fishing – gathering (fire use) – early animal domestication (not an

agricultural economy); intentional burials (Bagor); rock art (Bhimbetka) – animal remains (dog, cattle, sheep, elephant,

rhinoceros).

y Tools: Microliths (tiny stone tools of geometric shapes) + composite tools (hafted to wood/bone)

y Sites:

– Bhimbetka (Madhya Pradesh): Mesolithic rock paintings

– Bagor and Tilwara (Rajasthan): Largest Mesolithic site in India, animal domestication evident

– Langhnaj (Gujarat): Human skeletal remains found

– Sarai Nahar Rai (Uttar Pradesh): Burials and microliths found

– Mahadaha (Uttar Pradesh): Evidence of fishing and hunting

– Pachpadra basin (Rajasthan)

Neolithic Period (~6000 – 1000 BCE)

y About: Final stage of the Stone Age – use of new technology to create stone tools + new patterns of housing

y Lifestyle: Food gathering – surplus food production; sedentary village life – agriculture (wheat, barley, rice); dominant

animal domestication – pit & urn burials (regional variation)

y Tools: Polished stone tools (axes); Pottery (hand-made, later wheel-made)

y Sites:

– Mehrgarh (Balochistan, now in Pakistan) – Earliest Neolithic site in South Asia (wheat, barley), evidence for drilling

human tooth

– Koldihwa (Uttar Pradesh) – Earliest evidence of rice cultivation

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 7

4

Bronze Age (~2600 BCE – 1900 BCE)

y About: Phase of urbanisation in India – mastery of alloying copper and tin to create bronze (Bronze as dominant metal),

majorly coincides with IVC phase in India

y Lifestyle: Planned urban centres with standardised bricks, weights & drainage; surplus agriculture with internal–external

trade (Lothal dockyard); specialised crafts, standardised script & social stratification; standardised red/painted pottery;

simple pit burials with minimal goods.

y Sites: Sinauli (Uttar Pradesh), Daimabad (Maharashtra), Bhagwanpura (Haryana), Gandhara Grave Culture sites (NW

region), IVC Sites

Iron Age (~1200 BCE – 600 BCE)

y About: Widespread use of iron tools and weapons – enabled large-scale agriculture, forest clearance, and emergence of

early kingdoms.

– Recent excavations in Sivagalai, Tamil Nadu suggest possible iron usage as early as 3345 BCE

y Lifestyle: Rural settlements & fortified towns; intensive agriculture, crafts & trade – iron smelting/forging; emergence of

social stratification and political centres.

y Pottery: Painted Grey Ware (early) and Northern Black Polished Ware (later).

y Burials: Urn Burials, Megalithic burials with iron implements (especially South India).

y Sites:

– Hastinapur, Mathura, Ahichchhatra, Malhar (Uttar Pradesh)

– Panipat, Rupnagar, Bhagwanpura (Haryana/Punjab)

– Paiyampalli, Sivagalai, Mayiladumparai, Adichanallur (Tamil Nadu)

Megalithic culture (~1000 BCE – 300 CE): characterized by stone-built burial markers (megaliths)

y Burial types – Urn/pit/cist/sarcophagus (grave goods – iron tools, gold

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 8

5

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to Indian History, Alexander Rea, A. H. Longhurst, Robert Sewell, James

Burgess and Walter Elliot were associated with: [2023]

- (a) archaeological excavations
- (b) establishment of English Press in Colonial India
- (c) establishment of churches in Princely States
- (d) construction of railways in Colonial India

2. Who of the following had first deciphered the edicts of Emperor Ashoka? [2016]

- (a) Georg Buhler
- (b) James Prinsep
- (c) Max Muller
- (d) William Jones

Answers: 1.(a), 2.(b)

Indologists

Scholar Major Contributions / Achievements

Georg Bühler Pioneer in Indian epigraphy; worked extensively on Ashokan inscriptions; contributed to the study of

Brahmi script

James Prinsep Deciphered Brahmi and Kharosthi scripts (1837); enabled reading of Ashokan edicts

Max Müller Editor of Sacred Books of the East; major role in Vedic studies; popularised Aryan theory (academic, not archaeological)

William Jones Founder of Asiatic Society of Bengal (1784); proposed Indo-European language family; promoted study

of ancient Indian texts; translated Shakuntalam, Gita Govinda, Manusmriti, etc; studied Indian plants and

giving Sanskrit, Roman & Arabic names to each

Alexander

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 9

6

Indus Valley Civilisation

(3300-1300 BCE)

The Indus Valley Civilisation represents the first phase of urbanisation in the Indian subcontinent. It is also known as the Harappan

Culture, as Harappa was the first site discovered. While the civilisation was in its peak, several cultures, namely, Mesolithic and

Neolithic cultures prevailed in other parts of India. Harappan culture is divided into various phases (Early – Mature – Late). The

urban phase was prevalent in the mature Harappan period and began to decline afterwards.

2

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. The famous female figurine known as ‘Dancing Girl’, found at Mohenjo-daro, is made of:

[2025]

- (a) Carnelian
- (b) Clay
- (c) Bronze
- (d) Gold

2. Which one of the following ancient towns is well-known for its elaborate system of water

harvesting and management by building a series of dams and channelizing water into

connected reservoirs? [2021]

- (a) Dholavira
- (b) Kalibangan
- (c) Rakhigarhi
- (d) Ropar

3. Which one of the following is not a Harappan site? [2019]

- (a) Chanhudaro
- (b) Kot Diji

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 10

7

Features of IVC

Geographical

Extension

Northernmost: Manda (Chenab river) in settlements + Shortugai (Afghanistan) as trading outpost;

Southernmost: Daimabad (Maharashtra); Easternmost: Alamgirpur (Ganga-Yamuna Doab);

Westernmost: Suktagendor (Dasht River)

Town Planning y City division: Lower Town (residential areas) + Citadel (On higher ground); Grid pattern cities –

Baked bricks in interlocking pattern – standardised brick ratio (1:2:4)

y Housing: one or two storeys high + rooms built around courtyard (no windows in walls), private

sanitation; use of stone and wood

y Public bath a common feature – Great Bath at Mohenjo-Daro

y Drainage: Advanced covered drainage linked to cesspits (houses built along them)

y Granaries: on an upraised platform with air ducts for ventilation

y Advanced water system: Water reservoir at Dholavira + Great Bath at Mohenjodaro

Society & Social

Organisation

y Social stratification: house-size variation – moderate, non-rigid hierarchy; patriarchal or matriarchal

society (depiction of both male and female figures)

y Political structure: No clear evidence of kings, royal tombs or standing armies (suggesting possibly

decentralised governance)

y Women's position: female terracotta figurines (Harappa, Mohenjo-daro) + –Dancing Girl– bronze

(Mohenjo-daro) – social visibility

y Burial practices: fire altars – primary burials dominant (pottery, beads,

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 11

8

Important IVC Sites

Mohenjo-daro

(Bank of Indus,
Sindh, Pakistan)

y Called the “Mound of the Dead” due to multiple superimposed city layers and human skeletal

remains, indicating a sudden decline.

y Great Bath “ ritual bathing; waterproofed with bitumen

y Advanced drainage system

y Great Granary structures

y Seal of Pashupati (Proto-Shiva); bronze dancing girl; bearded man statue

y 2 Mesopotamian seals; large number of seals; dice

y Saddle querns for grinding cereals; Cotton Textile hub

y Better preserved site than Harappa

Harappa

(Bank of Ravi,
Punjab, Pakistan)

y First site to be discovered

y 6 granaries in a row with air ducts & workmen’s quarters

y Virgin-Goddess seal; stone symbols of Lingam & Yoni; painted pottery; clay figures of Mother

Goddess;

y Evidence of coffin burial; Cemetery-H culture (Late Harappan phase)

y Destroyed site by brick robbers

Dholavira

(Rann of Kachchh,

Gujarat)

y Only Harappan city divided into three parts: Citadel, Middle Town, Lower Town

y Advanced water management system (underground reservoirs, channels,

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 12

9

Kalibangan

(Ghaggar river,

Rajasthan)

y Name derived from Kali, meaning black, and Bangan meaning bangle (excavated terracotta bangles)

y Showcases both early and mature Harappan culture

y Fire altars associated with ritual activity

y World's™ earliest ploughed field evidence found; Earliest form of artificial irrigation

y Structure of Great Bath found

y No proper drainage system in lower town, highlighting regional differences

y Citadel as a fortified parallelogram.

y Extended burial for ordinary person, urn burial for a person from lower social strata, (Earthen) Pot

burial with precious materials showing faith in life after death.

y Pottery not as well fired as that of Harappa.

Ropar

(Bank of Sutlej,

Punjab)

y Buildings made of stone and soil

y Dog buried with humans.

y Inscribed steatite seal with typical Indus pictographs.

y Oval pit burials.

Banawali

(Hisar, Haryana)

y Oval-shaped settlement with unique radial street pattern

y Evidence of ploughed fields

y Yields the largest number of charred barley grains found at any IVC site

Chanhudaro

(Sindh, Pakistan)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 13

10

Sculpture y Dancing Girl: Bronze figurine from Mohenjo-daro (world's oldest bronze sculpture); made using lost-wax

(cire perdue) technique; tribhanga™ dancing posture, minimal clothing and confident posture shows

advanced Harappan bronze-casting skill

y Bearded Priest (Priest-King): Material Steatite; Site Mohenjo-daro; Features Trefoil patterned

shawl, half-closed eyes

y Male Torso: Material Red sandstone; Site Harappa; Features Well-proportioned body, socket

holes in the neck and shoulders for the attachment of head and arms

y Mother Goddess: Material Baked clay; Sites Widespread over multiple sites; Types Female

figurines, animals, toys

Beads and

Ornaments

y Materials: Carnelian, jasper, lapis lazuli, agate, shell, faience, gold, silver, copper

y Types: Beads, bangles, necklaces, earrings, anklets

! Girdles, earrings and anklets were worn only by women

Major Developments in Harappan Archaeology

The Indus Valley Civilisation declined from about 1900 BCE. Changes in climate, decline of the trade with Mesopotamia, and the

drying of the river and water resources due to continuous drought are some of the reasons attributed by historians for the decline.

Invasions, floods and shifting of the river course are also cited as reasons for the ruin of Indus civilization. In course of time, the

people shifted to the southern and eastern directions from the Indus region.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 14

11

Vedic Period

(1500-600 BC)

The Vedic Period (c. 1500–600 BCE) marks the transition from pastoral to agrarian society in India, which emerged after IVC. This

period is known for the composition of the Vedas, evolution of social and political institutions, early rituals, and gradual emergence

of kingdoms, varna system, and settled life.

Difference between IVC and Vedic Period

Dimension IVC Period Early Vedic/ Rig Vedic Period

Settlement Pattern Urban, planned cities, grid layout, drainage Rural / semi-nomadic, no urban planning

Economy Agriculture + craft production + long-distance

trade + mostly fine wheelmade plain pottery

Pastoral economy; wealth measured in cattle +

Ochre-Coloured Pottery (OCP)

Warfare No clear evidence of organised warfare Martial society; chariots and weapons

Horse Horse largely absent (debated and inconclusive

remains found at Surkotada)

Predominant domestication of horse (ashva)

Metals Known Copper, bronze, gold, silver; no iron Gold, silver, copper; iron only in later Vedic

Political

Organisation

Central authority implied from city planning and

citadel, nature unclear

Tribal polity; rajan, sabha, samiti

Social Structure Stratification unclear; no textual caste evidence Early varna system, relatively flexible

Religion Mother goddess, Pashupati, nature & animal

worship

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 15

12

Social structure

and institutions

y Social order – Egalitarian; Varna based on

color or occupation, not birth; Earliest

mention of Varna system in 10th Mandal

(last mandal) of Rig Veda

y Women – High status; attended Sabha/

Vidatha; education allowed – poets like

Apala, Ghosha, Lopamudra; marriage

– free to choose partner + no evidence of

child marriage or sati

Gotra and Ashrama

systems not established

y Marriage – typically monogamous marriage

but chiefs occasionally practised polygamy

y Social order – Rigid Varna system based on

birth; emergence of untouchability (Chandalas);

upper three classes entitled to Upanayana and

were called Dwija

y Women – Decline in status – excluded from

assemblies; marriage – Beginning of child

marriage, dowry, sati and prohibition of widow

remarriage

y Gotra and Ashrama (Brahmacharya,

Grihastha, Vanprastha, Sanyasa) systems

established

y Marriage – Despite the prevalence of polygamy,

monogamous marriages were preferred

Note: Full-fledged "untouchability" as a social

institution is generally considered a later development

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 16

13

Sub-classification of Vedas

Samhitas First part of the Vedas – Contains poetic mantras concerned with nature and deities (Karma Kanda

segment); they are named after the Vedas they belong to.

Brahmanas y Second part of the Vedas – Contains prose texts explaining mantras in Samhita; Explanation of

rituals and sacrifices associated with each Veda

y Each Veda has several Brahmanas: Rig Veda – Aitareya and Kausitaki Brahmana; Sukla Yajurveda

– Satapatha Brahmana; Atharvaveda – Gopatha Brahmana; Samaveda – Jaiminiya Brahmana

Aranyakas Third part of Vedas – Contains forest texts developed by hermits living in forests; Symbolic

interpretation of rituals dealing with mysticism; Shift from ritual to contemplation

Upanishads y Last part of Vedas – Contains philosophical conclusions attached to Vedas (Vedantas); incorporates

parables to explain complex concepts, composed earlier than the Puranas.

(Total of 108 Upanishads

classified according to the Vedas)

y Famous Upanishads:

– Brihadaranyaka (Rigveda): Yagnavalkya-Gargi debates; mentions Aham Brahmasmi, Asato Ma

Sadgamaya, Sarve Bhavantu Sukhinah

– Chandogya (Samaveda): mentions – Tat Tvam Asi –

– Katha (Yajurveda): Dialogue between Nachiketa and Yama

– Mundaka (Atharvaveda): mentions – Satyameva Jayate –

– Aitreya (Rigveda): Emphasises Atman as supreme reality

– Mahopanishad (Atharvaveda): mentions Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam

– Jabala: Four ashrams (Brahmacharya, Garhasthya, Vanaprastha, Sannyas)

Other Vedic Texts

Vedangas y Limbs (angas) that emerged to simplify the (archaic) language of

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 17

14

Terms Used in Vedic Period

y â€˜Indo-Europeanâ€™ and â€˜Indo-Aryanâ€™ â€“ Linguistic; not Racial terms

y Arya â€“ How composers of the Rig Veda described themselves

y Gojit â€“ Winner of cows/Hero; Gavisthi â€“ Search/War for cows; Gaun â€“ Places where cattle are kept

y Govikartanaâ€“ Forest chief; Sthapatiâ€“ master builder/architect

y Vapâ€“ To sow

y Gavyutiâ€“ Measure of distance; Godhuliâ€“ Measure of time

y Duhitri â€“ Daughter, one who milks cow; Sabhavati â€“ Women attending the assembly

y Sangrihitri â€“ Responsible for mandatory tributes and tax collection in later Vedic Period

y Shresthinsâ€“ Guilds or organisation of merchants; Panisâ€“Traders; Varthakaâ€“ Merchant class

y Takshanâ€“ Carpenter; Jivagribha and Ugraâ€“ Police Officers; Bhagadughaâ€“Tax Collector; Palagalaâ€“ Messenger;

Madhyamasiâ€“ Mediator in disputes; Kshataâ€“ Keeper of the Kingâ€™s household; Akshvapaâ€“ Accountant; Spasaâ€“ Spy;

Sutaâ€“ Charioteer

y Goghnaâ€“ Guest/Atithi-satkara

y Ashvamedha Yajnaâ€“ Ritual to proclaim a kingâ€™s territorial sovereignty through the unhindered movement of a sacrificial horse.

y Vajapeya Yajnaâ€“ Sacrifice performed to enhance royal power and prestige, marked by a symbolic chariot race

y Rajasuya Yajnaâ€“ Consecration ritual that formally legitimised a rulerâ€™s kingship and supremacy

y Niyogaâ€“ Special type of widow remarriage

y Rivers:

â™¦ Indus - Sindhu

â™¦ Jhelum - Vitasta

â™¦ Chenab - Asikni / Chandrabhaga

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 18

15

Mahajanapadas

(600 – 321 BCE)

The transition from the Later Vedic age to the Mahajanapada period marked a shift from clan-based, ritual society to territorial

states and renewed urbanisation. Emerging around the 6th century BCE, Mahajanapadas reflected iron technology, agricultural

surplus, and centralised authority, paving the way for empires like Magadha and the Mauryas. K. P. Jayaswal, in his seminal work

"Hindu Polity", highlighted the existence of early republican traditions in ancient India.

4

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to ancient India (600-322 BC), consider the following pairs: [2025]

Territorial: River flowing in the region

I. Asmaka: Godavari

II. Kamboja: Vipasa

III. Avanti: Mahanadi

IV. Kosala: Sarayu

How many of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

(a) Only one

(b) Only two

(c) Only three

(d) All the four

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 19

16

y Mahajanapadas (great kingdoms) were categorized into monarchies and republics.

â™| Monarchy: Centralised administration â†' Kingship hereditary; Sole revenue rights with king; Standing army

present; Vedic orthodoxy dominant

â™| Republics (Gana Sangha): No single authorityâ†' Tribal chiefs chosen collectively; Revenue rights shared; Priestly

influence limited and varied across republics

y Sources: Ancient texts like the Buddhist Anguttara Nikaya and Jaina Bhagavati Sutra list 16 independent states

y Factors responsible: Use of iron tools â†' forest clearance; Agricultural surplus â†' Growth of trade & towns; Emergence of

private property

16 Mahajanapadas

Magadha

(Present day Bihar)

y Capitals: Rajagriha â†' Pataliputra (Shifted by Udayin)

y Rulers: Bimbisara, Ajatashatru, Udayin (Haryanka dynasty)

y Rivers: Ganga, Son, Champa, Gandak

y Availability of iron aided military power

y Emerged as the centre of Buddhism and Jainism

y First Buddhist Council (Rajagriha)

y Magadha's rise due to: Fertile alluvial soil; Elephants for warfare; River transport; Strong rulers

Kosala

(Present day Eastern

Uttar Pradesh)

y Capital: Shravasti

y Ruler: Prasenajit ruled as Buddhaâ€™s contemporary

y River: Sarayu

y Included Lumbini, the birthplace of Gautama Buddha

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 20

17

Malla

(Present day Eastern

Uttar Pradesh, North

Bihar)

y Capitals: Kusinara, Pava functioned as Gana Sangha (republic);

y River: Rapti

y Buddha attained Mahaparinirvana at Kusinara

Kuru

(Present day Delhi,

Haryana, Western Uttar

Pradesh)

y Capitals: Indraprastha, Hastinapura

y Rivers: Ganga, Yamuna

y Emerged as a centre of later Vedic culture

Panchala

(Present day Western &

Central Uttar Pradesh)

y Capitals: Ahichchhatra (North), Kampilya (South)

y River: Ganga

y Contained Kannauj

Surasena

(Present day Mathura

region)

y Capital: Mathura

y River: Yamuna ; Region was associated with Krishna

y Buddha visited Mathura

Gandhara

(Present day Pakistan)

y Capital: Taxila developed as a major centre of learning

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 21

18

Nanda Dynasty

(345 BCE - 321 BCE):

First non-Kshatriya
dynasty

y Mahapadma Nanda: Claimed to be an ekarat (sole sovereign) and
sarva-kshatrantaka

(destroyer of Kshatriyas); Expanded Magadha by annexing Kalinga; Known as
Ugrasena due

to a massive standing army

y Dhana Nanda: Ruled at the time of Alexander's invasion; referred to as
Agrammes

(Xandrames) by greek historian Diodorus; Credited with the invention of
Nandopakramani

(measurement system)

On the NorthWestern

Borders

y Achaemenid (Persian) Expansion: 6th–4th centuries BCE; Gandhara, Kamboja
and Sindh

formed the satrapy of Hindush; Introduced Persian administration, tribute
system and military

routes that connect with north-western India

y Alexander's Invasion: Motivated by expansion, wealth and exploration;
Advanced into India

after defeating Persia; Faced resistance from Aspasiens and Assacenes in
north-west

y King Ambhi of Taxila: First Indian ruler encountered; Submitted
peacefully; allied with

Alexander against Porus

y King Porus: Ruled Paurava (between Jhelum and Chenab); Fought Alexander at
Battle of

Hydaspes (326 BCE); Reinstated by Alexander as a subordinate ruler

The age of Mahajanapadas was a transformative phase marked by state

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 22

19

Buddhism

Buddhism and Jainism emerged as major heterodox sects in the post-Vedic period due to growing scepticism toward established

customs and orthodoxy, resistance from the Kshatriyas against Brahmanical ritual dominance, and opposition to excessive cattle

sacrifice, which hindered the expanding agricultural economy.

These religions gained strong support from the Vaishya community as they promoted non-violence—reducing warfare and encouraging

trade—rejected the Dharmasutras’ condemnation of moneylending with interest, and initially showed little concern for the rigid varna

system.

Buddhism, founded by Gautam Buddha, emerged in the 6th century BCE as a potent "Sramanic" or heterodox religion, challenging

the established socio-religious norms and Vedic ritualism.

5

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to ancient India, Gautama Buddha was generally known by which of the

following epithets? [2024]

1. Nayaputta
2. Shakyamuni
3. Tathagata

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) None of the above

2. Which of the following kingdoms were associated with the life of the Buddha? [2014]

1. Avanti
2. Gandhara

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 23

20

Great Events and Associated Places with Buddha's Life

y Lumbini: Birthplace of Siddhartha Gautama (Symbol: Elephant)

y Kapilavastu: Childhood palace; site of the Mahabhinishkramana (Great Renunciation; Symbol: Horse)

y Bodh Gaya: Sambodhi (Attained Enlightenment; Symbol: Bodhi Tree)

y Sarnath: Dharma-Chakra-Pravartana (First Sermon; Symbol: Wheel)

y Kushinagar: Mahaparinirvana (Final Passing; Symbol: Stupa)

y Shravasti: Site of many sermons; associated with patron Anathapindika

y Rajgir (Rajagriha): Major teaching site

y Kaushambi: One of the early capitals where Buddhism spread

y Nalanda: Site of the great ancient monastic university

Different Names and Epithets of Buddha

y Siddhartha Gautama – Personal name (He who achieves his goal) + clan name

y Āśākyamuni – Sage of the Āśākyā clan

y Sugata – The well-gone; one who attained Nirvāṇa

y Tathāgata – The thus-come/thus-gone; knower of ultimate reality

y Jina / Arhat – Victor; one who conquered inner defilements

y Lokavid / Lokajyeśtha – Knower of the worlds; foremost in the world

y Bhagavat – The Blessed One

y Mahākāruṇika – The Great Compassionate One

Buddhist Philosophy and Teachings

Pratītya samutpāda y Core Buddhist doctrine stating that all phenomena arise together in a mutually interdependent

web of cause and effect.

y Nothing exists independently; rather, "if this exists, that exists". It serves as a middle path

between eternalism and annihilation.

y According to Buddha, the Middle Path (Madhyam Marg) describes the character of the Noble

Eightfold Path that leads to liberation.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History -- Part 24

21

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 25

22

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. In which one of the following regions was Dhanyakataka, which flourished as a

prominent Buddhist centre under the Mahasanghikas, located? [2023]

- (a) Andhra
- (b) Gandhara
- (c) Kalinga
- (d) Magadha

2. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements: [2020]

- 1. Sthaviravadins belong to Mahayana Buddhism.
- 2. Lokottaravadin sect was an offshoot of Mahasanghika sect of Buddhism.
- 3. The deification of Buddha by Mahasanghikas fostered Mahayana Buddhism.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

3. Consider the following: [2019]

- 1. Deification of the Buddha
- 2. Treading the path of Bodhisattvas
- 3. Image worship and rituals

Which of the above is/are the feature/features of Mahayana Buddhism?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

4. With reference to the religious history of India. Consider the following statements: [2017]

- 1. Sautrantika and Sammitiya were the sects of Jainism.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 26

23

Schools, Sects & Internal Developments

Buddhism gradually split into several sects due to differences in philosophical views, rituals, and methods of expansion. The first significant division occurred during the Second Buddhist Council (~383 BCE), leading to the formation of Sthaviravada and

Mahasanghika. Over time, these divisions further developed into major traditions such as Theravada, Mahayana, and Vajrayana, each having unique doctrines and practices.

Major Sects of Buddhism

Sthaviravada

(Elders' Tradition)

- y Strict adherence to Vinaya (monastic discipline) and original teachings of Buddha.

- y Realist philosophical approach – existence as a combination of unstable elements.

- y Emphasised attainment of Arhatship (individual liberation from the cycle of rebirth).

- y Doctrinal base from which Theravada Buddhism later evolved.

Mahasanghika

(Great Community)

- y More liberal section of the Sangha – Believed that the original nature of the mind is pure but

corrupted by worldly desires.

- y Viewed the Buddha as a transcendental and supra-human figure.

- y Intellectual foundation for the later emergence of Mahayana Buddhism.

- y Dhanyakataka (Amaravati): capital for the Satavahana dynasty; stronghold for Mahasanghika

school of Buddhism and its sub-sects (Caityakas)

- y Sub-sects:

- Lokottaravadin: Concept of Lokottara Buddha (Supernatural Buddha)

- Ekavyavaharika: Emphasized unity of teachings

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 27

24

Theravada y Continuation of Sthaviravada – Focuses on personal liberation through attainment of Arhatship.

y Preserves the Pali Canon (Tripitaka) as authoritative scripture.

y Spread mainly across Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia, and Laos.

Mahayana

Buddhism

y Advocates the Bodhisattva ideal, encouraging practitioners to work for universal salvation.

y Recognises the divine and devotional aspects of the Buddha. – deification of the Buddha; image

worship and rituals

y Developed major philosophical schools such as:

– Madhyamika School – Founded by Nagarjuna; emphasises the doctrine of emptiness (Shunyata).

– Yogachara School (Vijnanavada) – Advocates the Consciousness-Only doctrine (Vijñāptimātra); against the extreme nihilism of Madhyamika

y Prominent Mahayana Centres – Nāgārjunakośa (Andhra Pradesh); Dharmarakṣita-aka (Amaravati,

Andhra Pradesh)

Vajrayana y Developed from Mahayana around the early medieval period.

y Incorporates Tantric rituals, mantras, meditation techniques, and esoteric practices.

y Includes worship of Bodhisattvas such as Avalokitesvara and Tara.

y Tibetan Buddhism preserved Vajrayana teachings through four main schools.

– The Nyingma school, linked to Padmasambhava, emphasised the Dzogchen tradition.

– The Kagyu school focused on meditation and includes the Karma Kagyu, led by the

Karmapa.

– The Sakya school developed strong scholastic traditions

– The Gelug school, founded by Tsongkhapa, stressed discipline and learning and is led by the

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 28

25

â™¦ Kâ™†itigarbha: Famous for his immense vow to save all beings from hell and not attain Buddhahood until all hells are

empty

â™¦ Samantabhadra: Bodhisattva of Practice and Conduct; associated with vows and meditation

â™¦ Skanda: Protector of Buddhist teachings and monasteries

â™¦ ÄƒkÄ•Ägarbha: Bodhisattva of infinite space and wisdom

â™¦ SarvanivÄ•raâ†aviâ†Ekambhin: Bodhisattva who removes obstacles

â™¦ Tara: Female Bodhisattva of compassion

â™¦ Vasudhara: Represents wealth, prosperity, and abundance

â™¦ Amitabha: Bodhisattva of infinite light and life

â™¦ Sitatapatra: Embodiment of protection

â™¦ Dipankara: A past Buddha, attained enlightenment before Gautama Buddha

Terms Related to Buddhism

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to the cultural history of India, which one of the following is the correct

description of the term â€˜paramitasâ€™? [2020]

(a) The earliest Dharmashastra texts written in aphoristic (sutra) style

(b) Philosophical schools that did not accept the authority of Vedas

(c) Perfections whose attainment led to the Bodhisattva path

(d) Powerful merchant guilds of early medieval South India

2. With reference to the cultural history of India, consider the following pairs: [2020]

1. Parivrajaka â€” Renunciant and Wanderer

2. Shramana â€” Priest with a high status

3. Upasaka â€” Lay follower of Buddhism

Which of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

(a) 1 and 2 only

(b) 1 and 3 only

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 29

26

Related Terms

y Pudgalavada: A "person" (pudgala), neither identical with nor separate from the body and mind, to explain karma,

rebirth, and liberation without accepting a permanent soul.

y Bodhisattvas: Enlightened beings who delay Nirvana to help others attain liberation, embodying compassion, self-

sacrifice, and practising the Mahayana path with the Paramitas

y Paramitas "6 Spiritual virtues (generosity, ethical conduct, patience, diligence, meditation, and wisdom) practised by

Bodhisattvas to attain enlightenment and help others.

y Āśramaśīla "Renunciant ascetic who abandoned household life to pursue liberation through meditation and austerities.

y Parivrajaka "Wandering ascetic or mendicant who travelled and engaged in teaching and philosophical debates.

y Agrahāra "Brahmana beneficiary or resident of a tax-free land grant (agrahāra) given for religious or educational

purposes.

y Māgadha "Person or language associated with the Magadha region; Professionals who memorized chronicles, dynastic

histories and epic tales

y Bhikkhu "Fully ordained Buddhist monk following strict monastic discipline.

y Upasaka "Lay follower of Buddhism supporting the Sangha and practising the teachings.

y Nirvana "State of ultimate liberation where desire, suffering, and rebirth cease.

y Shunyavada "Doctrine stating all phenomena lack permanent essence and exist through interdependence.

y Dvadashanga "Twelffold classification of the Buddha's teachings, especially recognised in Mahayana tradition.

y Ten Great Disciples:

āśāriputra (Upatissa) "Foremost in Wisdom (prajā)

āśā Moggallāna (Maudgalyāyana) "Foremost in Supernatural Powers (āddhi).

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 30

27

Buddhist Art

Anthropomorphic

Buddha Sculptures

y Gandhara School (Northwest India): Shows strong Greco-Roman influence.

Features wavy hair,

realistic draped robes (like a toga), mustache, and athletic build.

y Mathura School (Central India): Indigenous Indian style. Features curly

hair, tightly clinging robe,

broad shoulders, and a characteristic smile.

Mudras (Symbolic

Hand Gestures)

y Recreate the image with rearrangement (spread horizontally)

3. Which one of the following statements is correct? [2021]

(a) Ajanta Caves lie in the gorge of Waghora river.

(b) Sanchi Stupa lies in the gorge of Chambal river.

(c) Pandu-lena Cave Shrines lie in the gorge of Narmada river.

(d) Amaravati Stupa lies in the gorge of Godavari river.

4. With reference to Indian history, who among the following is a future Buddha, yet to

come to save the world? [2018]

(a) Avalokiteshvara

(b) Lokeshvara

(c) Maitreya

(d) Padmapani

5. With reference to Buddhist history, tradition and culture in India, consider the following

pairs: [2014]

Famous shrine: Location

1. Tabo monastery and temple complex: Spiti Valley

2. Lhotsava Lhakhang: Zaskar Valley

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 31

28

Buddhist Architecture

Stupa y Meaning: Dome-shaped relic mound built over Buddha's remains or sacred objects; later became

symbolic worship structure.

y Originated from pre-Buddhist burial mounds and later adopted by Buddhism.

y Key Parts: Anda (hemispherical dome), Harmika (square railing on top), Chattra (umbrella-like

spire), Vedika (railing), Torana (ornate gateway).

y Important Stupas

• Sanchi (MP) – Built by Ashoka; best preserved early stupa

• Bharhut (MP) – Early aniconic art of Buddha

• Dhamek, Sarnath (UP) – Site of First Sermon

• Mahabodhi, Bodh Gaya (Bihar) – Enlightenment site (UNESCO)

• Amaravati (AP) – Mahayana narrative reliefs

• Nagarjunakonda (AP) – Major Mahayana centre

• Kesariya (Bihar) – Among largest stupas

• Piprahwa (UP) – Buddha relics; recently returned to India; discovery (1898) by William

Claxton Peppercor; Includes bone fragments, soapstone and crystal caskets; Brahmi script

inscription

• Ramabhar, Kushinagar (UP) – Mahaparinirvana site

Chaitya Prayer hall with a stupa at the apsidal end; meant for collective worship.

y Bhaja (Maharashtra) – Early Hinayana chaitya

y Karla (Maharashtra) – Largest chaitya hall

y Ajanta Cave – Mahayana chaitya with Buddha image

y Kanheri (Mumbai) – Multiple chaityas, major Buddhist centre

y Nasik (Pandavleni) – Satavahana patronage inscriptions

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 32

29

Vihara Monastic residence with cells around a courtyard; used for living, study, and teaching.

y Ajanta Caves – Decorated Mahayana viharas with murals

y Kanheri Viharas – Over 100 caves; long monastic occupation

y Nasik Viharas – Donative inscriptions; trade-linked monasteries

y Ellora Caves – Dating to late Hinayana–early Mahayana phase

y Pitalkhora – Among the earliest rock-cut Buddhist caves

Other Caves y Barabar Caves (Bihar) – Earliest rock-cut caves in India with Mauryan polish; associated with

Ajivikas

y Saru Maru Caves/ Pangoraria or Budhani caves (Madhya Pradesh) – Buddhist site with multiple

stupas and dwellings.

Major Monasteries y Veluvana Monastery (Rajgir, Bihar): AKA the Bamboo Grove, recognized as the one of first

Buddhist monastery gifted to Gautama Buddha by King Bimbisara

y Tabo Monastery (Himachal Pradesh) – One of the oldest monasteries (founded 996 CE); known as

the "Ajanta of the Himalayas" for its ancient murals.)

y Aichi Monastery / Stongdey Monastery (Ladakh) – One of the largest monasteries in Zaskar;

part of the Gelugpa school of Tibetan Buddhism.

y Thiksey Monastery (Ladakh) – Often called "Mini Potala," it is a major Gelugpa monastery.

y Hemis Monastery (Ladakh) – Largest and wealthiest monastery in Ladakh, belonging to the

Drukpa Kagyu school.

y Rumtek Monastery (Sikkim) – The seat-in-exile of the Karmapa, head of the Karma Kagyu

school.

y Lhotsava Lhakhang Temple (Himachal Pradesh) – It is a 12th C Temple, situated in Nako.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 33

30

Canonical Literature

Tripitaka

(Three Baskets)

Contains Buddha's teachings and monastic code, believed to have been organized at the First Buddhist

Council and orally transmitted for centuries.

y Vinaya Pitaka (Basket of Discipline): Rules and regulations for monks and nuns – Explains origin

and circumstances of each rule

y Sutta Pitaka (Basket of Discourses): Contains the core teachings (Dhamma) of the Buddha.

– Five collections: Nikayas: Digha (long), Majjhima (medium), Samyutta (grouped), Anguttara

(numerical), and Khuddaka (minor).

– Key texts include the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (First Sermon) and the Jataka Tales

(stories of Buddha's past lives).

y Abhidhamma Pitaka (Basket of Higher Doctrine): Philosophical analysis and systematization of

the teachings.

Mahayana

Literature

y Sutras:

– Lalitavistara – Biography of Buddha (Birth to First Sermon)

– Saddharma Pundarika (Lotus Sutra) – Emphasises unity and universality of Buddha's

teachings

– Prajna-paramita Sutras – Explain doctrine of Shunyata (Emptiness)

– Vaipulya Sutras – Expanded Mahayana teachings

y Vaipulya Sutras: A category for "expanded" or broad Mahayana discourses.

y Avadana Literature: Moral stories focusing on karma and the fruits of

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 34

31

Buddhism Chronological Patronage

Mahajanpada

(6th–5th BCE)

y Rulers of Mahajanpadas like Magadha, Kosala, etc.

y Merchants & guilds (Setthis) donated for sanghas, monasteries, cave excavations

Mauryan Period

(3rd BCE)

y Ashoka – State patronage; stupas, pillars, monasteries; spread of Buddhism beyond India

y Bindusara (indirect) – Continuity of Mauryan support

Post-Mauryan Period

(2nd BCE – 2nd CE)

y Shungas – Limited/indirect patronage; continuation of stupa tradition

y Satavahanas – Major patrons of cave Buddhism (Bhaja, Karla, Nasik, Amaravati)

y Indo-Greeks (Menander/Milinda) – Support to Buddhism; cultural interaction

y Kushanas (Kanishka) – Strong patronage to Mahayana Buddhism; Gandhara–Mathura art

Gupta Period

(4th–6th CE)

y Secondary patronage; Buddhism coexisted with Brahmanism

y Growth of Mahayana viharas and Buddha images

Early Medieval Period

(7th–12th CE)

y Palas (Bengal–Bihar) – Greatest patrons of late Buddhism

y Harsha – Royal support to Nalanda (Mahayana Buddhism)

Decline Phase

(12th onwards)

y Loss of royal patronage

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 35

32

Jainism

Jainism emerged in the 6th century BCE as a radical ascetic response to the same societal upheavals that gave rise to Buddhism.

Vardhamana Mahavira (24th Tirthankara), propagated its core doctrines. It rejected the authority of the Vedic priesthood and the

growing materialism of urbanizing kingdoms like Magadha, instead championing a path of extreme non-violence (ahimsa), renunciation, and personal austerity.

Mahavira's Life

y Birth (540 BCE): Born as Vardhamana at Kumbhgrama near Vaiśālī (Bihar) in the Jñātrika (Nāya) clan

y Family: Father Siddhartha (chief of Jñātrikas); mother Trishala (Licchavi princess) – links with republican polity of Vaiśālī

y Renunciation and Asceticism: At the age of 30, renounced worldly life near Vaiśālī. Practised severe penance for 12 years, wandering mainly in Magadha and eastern India

y Enlightenment: Attained Kevala Jñāna at Jambhikagrama (present day Jamui, Bihar) on the banks of river Āśvīnī

y Teaching: Preached Jain doctrine across Magadha, Kosala, and Videha; organised Sangha of monks, nuns, and lay followers

y Death (Mahāvīra): Attained liberation at Pāvā (Pawapuri, Bihar) at the age of 72

y Names: Mahāvīra (Great Hero) – Vardhamana: Original birth name – Sanmati / Sanmatinatha: "Lord of the right

view" – Nigāṭha Nāyaputta/ Nāyaputta: "Nigāṭha" means "free from bonds". – Nāyaputta indicates that he belonged to

the Jñātrika (Nāya/Naya) clan.

Different Names and Epithets of Tirthankaras

y Tirthāṅkara: One who shows the path across the cycle of birth and death. There have been 24 Tirthankaras in Jainism

y Arhat: – Worthy One; one who has destroyed karmic bonds and attained spiritual purity

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 36

33

Jain Philosophy

Core Philosophical Framework in Jainism

Ultimate Goal y Moksha (Liberation) – Release of the soul (J  va) from the cycle of birth and death by eliminating

karmic bondage.

– Souls are not only the property of animal and plant life, but also of rocks, running water and

many other natural objects not looked on as living by other religious sects.

Jain Dualism

(Jiva – Ajiva)

y Jainism distinguishes between soul (Jiva) and matter (Ajiva); their interaction produces karma,

causing the cycle of rebirth, and liberation is achieved through austerity and strict self-discipline.

Path to Liberation:

Triratna

(Three Jewels)

y Samyak Dar  ana (Right Faith)

– Correct belief in Jain doctrines and the reality of soul and karma

y Samyak J    na (Right Knowledge)

– True knowledge of reality, free from doubt and error

y Samyak C    ritra (Right Conduct) – Ethical living through vows and self-discipline

Ethical Discipline:

Five Mah  vratas

(Great Vows)

y Ahims   – Absolute non-violence in thought, word, and deed

y Satya – Truthfulness

y Asteya – Non-stealing

y Brahmacharya – Celibacy / chastity (added by Mahavira)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History € Part 37

34

Differences between Jainism and Buddhism

y Concept of Soul: Jainism believes in an eternal soul (JÄ«va), while Buddhism rejects a permanent soul and follows the

doctrine of Anattā• (no-self).

y Karma: Jainism treats karma as a material substance binding the soul, whereas Buddhism views karma as a moral law of

actions and intentions.

y Cause of Bondage: Jainism links bondage to karmic matter caused by passions; Buddhism attributes it to desire (Trishna)

and ignorance (Avidya).

y Ethical Emphasis: Jainism promotes strict asceticism; Buddhism follows the Middle Path avoiding extremes.

y Caste: Jainism does not strongly oppose caste; Buddhism rejects caste distinctions and allows universal entry into Sangha.

y Rituals: Buddhism downplays sacrificial and mechanical ritualism compared to Jainism

y Women: Jainism (especially Digambara) restricts women's liberation in same birth; Buddhism allows women into monastic

order and accepts their spiritual potential.

y Monastic Discipline: Jain monks follow extremely strict austerities; Buddhist monastic rules are comparatively moderate.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to the religious practices in India, the "Sthanakvasi" sect belongs

to: [2018]

- (a) Buddhism
(b) Jainism
(c) Vaishnavism
(d) Shaivism

Answer: 1. (b)

Schools and Sects in Jainism

Major Sects under Jainism – Digambar and Svetambar

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 38

35

Jain Art and Architecture

Jain Art

Iconography of

Tirthankaras

y Austere and symbolic – reflects asceticism and non-violence. Images are generally nude

(especially Digambara), indicating renunciation.

y Tirthankaras are depicted either in Padmasana (seated meditation) or Kayotsarga (standing, detached posture)

y Each Tirthankara is identified by a distinct emblem (lanchhana) on the pedestal (e.g., bull for

Rishabhdev, lion for Mahavira). Faces are calm, with no divine ornamentation, emphasising

inner spirituality.

Sculptural Tradition y Mathura School: Developed under the Kushanas; Made of red spotted sandstone; Features –

rigid frontal posture, elongated arms, meditative expression; Introduction of Ayagapatas

(inscribed worship slabs).

y Important examples:

– Lohanipur Torso (Patliputra) – earliest polished Jain image.

– Kankali Tila (Mathura) – Jain stupa remains, sculptures, ayagapatas.

– Gopachal (Gwalior) – large rock-cut Tirthankaras.

– Vasantgarh hoard (Rajasthan) – bronze Jain icons showing sashandevatas (yaksha and

yakshi) under Shwetambara influence.

Painting Tradition y Dominated by miniature manuscript tradition. The most illustrated text remains Kalpa Sutra

(lives of Tirthankaras).

y Western Indian Style (Gujarat – Rajasthan – Malwa):

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 39

36

Temples (Jinalaya) y Standard components include Garbhagriha, Mandapa, Mukhmandapa, Shikhara,

Devakoshta, while distinctive features include:

• Chaumukh (four-faced) temple plan.

• Numerous pillars forming square bays with richly carved brackets.

y Major temple sites:

• Dilwara (Mt Abu, Rajasthan) – white marble, intricate carvings.

• Ranakpur (Rajasthan) – Maru-Gurjara style, 1444 pillars.

• Shikharji (Parasnath Hill, Jharkhand) – moksha site of 20 Tirthankaras.

• Khajuraho Jain Temples (Madhya Pradesh) – Chandela period, Nagara style.

• Palitana Temples (Shatrunjaya Hills, Gujarat) – place where Rishabhdev (Adinath)

delivered sermons; 800+ marble temples complex, Nagara style.

• Girnar Temples (Gujarat) – Associated with both Digambara and Svetambara;

Neminatha (22nd Tirthankara) attained moksha here.

Stupas y Early devotional structures, later replaced by Samavasarana concept. (Stupas are also known

as ‘Thupa’ in inscriptions.)

y Structural features: Cylindrical, three-tiered drum; High platform with stairway and torana;

Decorative railings and symbolic motifs.

y Mathura Jain Stupa (Kankali Tila): Dated to 1st century BCE–CE; Known through

Ayagapatas, depicting stupa forms and symbols; Influence of Persepolitan pillars seen.

Jain Literature

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to Indian history, consider the following texts: [2022]

1. Nettipakarana

2. Parishishtaparvan

3. Avadanashataka

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 40

37

Major Jain Scholars

y Bhadrabahu: Digambara Ācārya and spiritual teacher of Chandragupta Maurya; led migration of Jain monks to South

India during famine, helping spread Jainism.

y Sthulabhadra/Sthlabahu: Āśvetāmbara leader who presided over the First Jain Council at Pataliputra to compile and

preserve Jain teachings.

y Umaswami (Umāsvāti): Author of Tattvārtha Sāstra, the only Jain philosophical text accepted by both Digambara and

Āśvetāmbara sects.

y Kundakunda: Early Digambara philosopher; authored Samayasāra, Pravachanasāra, Panchastikāyasāra; emphasised

the concept of pure soul and spiritual liberation.

y Hemachandra: 12th-century Āśvetāmbara scholar under King Kumarapala; wrote Yogaśāstra (Jain ethics and conduct),

Parishishtaparvan (history of Jain teachers) and Trishashti Shalaka Purusha Charitra (Lives of 63 Great Men).

y Jinasena: 9th-century Digambara monk; initiated Trishashtilakshana Mahapurana / Ādi Purāṇa, covering Jain

cosmology and legendary history (later completed by Gunabhadra).

y Nemichandra: 10th-century Digambara scholar; wrote Dravyasamgraha (Jain metaphysics) and Gommatasara (nature of

soul and karma theory).

y Nayacandra Suri: wrote the Hammira-mahakavya (Sanskrit) āt' biography of 13th C Chahmana King Hammira

y Somadeva Suri: wrote Nitivakyaṃrta āt' on ethics, politics, and social norms (Sanskrit).

Jainism Chronological Patronage

y Mahajanapada: Rise of Jainism under Vardhamana Mahaviraāt' Strong support from merchant and trading communities

āt'Patronage from rulers of Magadha, Videha, Anga, etc.

y Mauryan Period: Chandragupta Maurya patronised Digambar linked to migration to Shravanabelagola āt' Sampriti

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 41

38

Mauryas (321 – 185 BCE) and

Post Mauryas (200 – 300 CE) 7The Nanda dynasty's reputedly autocratic administration, along with their perceived lower social status, created resentment

among several social groups, especially the Kshatriya warrior elite. This growing discontent ultimately facilitated the emergence

of Chandragupta Maurya as a powerful leader.

The Mauryan period began around 321 BCE and ended around 185 BCE. It witnessed the rise of the first empire to unify most of

the Indian subcontinent and introduced advanced and well-structured systems of governance.

Major Rulers

Chandragupta

Maurya

(321–297 BCE)

y Founder of Mauryan Empire; defeated Dhana Nanda with help of Chanakya

y Defeated Seleucus Nicator (305 BCE) – gained NW territories; Megasthenes sent as ambassador

(Indica); Called Sandrocottus by the Greek scholars

y Established centralised administration, standing army, espionage system

y Later adopted Jainism; performed Sallekhana

Bindusara

(c. 297–273 BCE)

y Expanded empire southwards up to Deccan (except Kalinga & deep south)

y Known as Amitrochates / Amitraghata ('Slayer of enemies') – mentioned in Patanjali's

Mahabhasya

y Maintained ties with Hellenistic kingdoms; Patronised Ajivikas

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 42

39

Ashoka

(c. 268–232 BCE)

y Kalinga War (261 BCE) → Adopted Dhamma, renounced Digvijaya

y First king to communicate directly with his subjects through inscriptions;
Ruled through Rock &

Pillar Edicts, Dhamma Mahamattas, welfare policies

y Promoted the policy of Dhammaghosa (spread of dharma) over Berigghosa
(war); sent Mahendra &

Sanghamitra to Sri Lanka

y Names in inscriptions:

→ Devanampiya, Piyadassi (Maski Edict)

→ Ashoka, Buddhaskya (Maski Edict)

→ Dharmasoka (Sarnath inscription)

Later Rulers y Dasharatha → Last Mauryan ruler issuing inscriptions

y Samprati → Jain patron; reconquered western & southern provinces

y Brihadratha → Last Mauryan ruler; killed by Pushyamitra Shunga (187 BCE) →
End of Mauryan

Empire

Mauryan Administration

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the → Pradesika →, → Rajulka → and → yuktā →
were important

officers at the: [2025]

(a) Village level administration

(b) district level administration

(c) provincial administration

(d) Level of the central administration

Mauryan Administration

Saptanga theory

of State

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 43

40

Provincial

Administration

y Provinces were governed by Kumaras / Aryaputras (usually royal princes), and were divided into

divisions headed by Pradeshikas.

y Province (Head) – Mandal (Commissioner) – Aahar (District – Sthanik) – Sthaniya (Group of 800

villages) – Dronamukh (Group of 400 villages) – Kharvatik (Group of 200 villages) – Sangrahan

(Group of 10 villages – Officer: Gopa) – Village (Gramani)

Province Capital

Magadha Pataliputra (Patna, Bihar)

Uttarapatha Taxila (Near Rawalpindi, Pak)

Dakshinapatha Suvarnagiri (Chitradurga, Karnataka)

Eastern India Tosali (Dhauligiri, Bhubaneswar)

Avantiratha Ujjain (Madhya Pradesh)

Kalinga Tasali/Dhauli (Odisha)

City

Administration

y Pradeshika: Responsible for tax collection, and law and order

y Nagarika: Head of city administration, assisted by Gopa and Sthanika

y Rajukas – District officers; judicial + administrative power

y Yuktas – Subordinate officials; revenue assessment

y Sthanikas – Headed groups of 5–10 villages; tax collection

y Gopas – Maintained village records and accounts

y Lohadhyaksha and Sauvarnika: Managed manufacturing center

y Gramika/Gramini – Village head;

y Gramvridhas: Village elders assisting the Gramika

y Rakshi (Police): Maintained public security

y Pataliputra City Administration: 6 committees – 5 members each; Functions

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 44

41

Other y Spinning and weaving – second most crucial occupation after agriculture

y Crafts – urban-based hereditary occupations with sons usually following their fathers

y Primary form of currency – silver coin called "pana"

y Widespread use of iron technology, punch-marked coins, Northern Black Polished Ware pottery,

construction using burnt bricks and ring wells, along with rapid urban growth.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. According to Kautilya's Arthashastra, which of the following are correct ? [2022]

1. A person could be a slave as a result of a judicial punishment.
2. If a female slave bore her master a son, she was legally free.
3. If a son born to a female slave was fathered by her master, the son was entitled to the legal status of the master's son.

Which of the statements given above are correct ?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Mauryan Society

Varna and

Caste System

y Society broadly organised along varna lines with roles linked to occupation.

y Megasthenes: Society divided into 7 groups – philosophers, cultivators, hunters/herdsmen, artisans/

traders, soldiers/overseers, spies, counselors.

– Hereditary in nature and intermarriage between groups not allowed

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 45

42

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following pairs: [2022]

Site of Ashoka's major rock edicts Location in the State of

1. Dhuli – Odisha
2. Erragudi – Andhra Pradesh
3. Jaugada – Madhya Pradesh
4. Kalsi – Karnataka

How many pairs given above are correctly matched ?

- (a) Only one pair
- (b) Only two pairs
- (c) Only three pairs
- (d) All four pairs

2. Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription?

“Whoever praises his religious sect or blames other sects out of excessive devotion

to his own sect, with the view of glorifying his own sect, he rather injures his own sect

very severely.” [2020]

- (a) Ashoka
- (b) Samudragupta
- (c) Harshavardhana
- (d) Krishnadeva Raya

3. In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is Ranyo Ashoka (King Ashoka)

mentioned along with the stone portrait of Ashoka? [2019]

- (a) Kanganahalli
- (b) Sanchi
- (c) Shahbazgarhi
- (d) Sohgauna

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 46

43

Pillars

y Purpose: Symbol of the State; to commemorate battle victories; Propagation of Dhamma

y Features: Monolithic, free-standing pillars; Made of Chunar sandstone with Mauryan mirror-like polish; uniformity

of style (highly polished); independently erected

y Two main parts:

â™| Shaft – Tall, smooth, tapering column

â™| Capital – Three components – Lotus-bell base; Abacus with floral/animal carvings; Animal sculpture (lion, bull, elephant, etc.)

Sarnath Pillar y Four lions – Power, courage, confidence, justice

y Abacus animals: Elephant – Maya's dream; Bull – Zodiac signal; Horse – Renunciation (Kanthaka);

Lion – Enlightenment

y Animals separated by Dharmachakras (four directions)

y National Emblem Link: Adapted in 1950; Shows three visible lions + Dharmachakra; Motto:

Satyameva Jayate (from the Mundaka Upanishad)

Other Pillars

y Lauriya Nandangarh (Bihar)

y Rampurva Pillar Bull Capital

(Bihar) y Vaishali Pillar

Edicts

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 47

44

y Ashoka issued 14 Major Rock Edicts, 7 Pillar Edicts, and Minor Rock Edicts; focus on social and moral principles based

on Buddhist philosophy.

y Composed in 3 languages: Prakrit, Greek, Aramaic; Written in 4 scripts: Brahmi, Kharoshthi, Greek, Aramaic

• Greek & Aramaic used in Afghanistan region

• Kharoshthi used in Gandhara region

y James Prinsep deciphered the Brahmi and Kharosthi script in 1837 – foundational key to reconstructing Mauryan

history

Pillar

Edicts

y Pillar Edict I: Ashoka's principles for the protection of people.

y Pillar Edict II: Defines Dhamma with compassion, truthfulness, virtue etc.

y Pillar Edict III: Asks subjects to control violence, cruelty, anger and envy.

y Pillar Edict IV: Duties and responsibilities of Rajukas.

y Pillar Edict V: List of birds and animals to be killed on certain days and not be killed at all.

y Pillar Edict VI: The policy of Dhamma.

y Pillar Edict VII: Ashoka describes all sect's desire for self-control and purity of mind

y Minor Pillar Edicts

• Exclusively inscribed on several of the pillars of Ashoka (eg; Sarnath, Sanchi etc). All are in the Prakrit

language in Brahmi script.

• Rummindei Pillar Edicts (Lumbini): mentions Ashoka's visit to Lumbini

Rock

Edicts

y 14 Major Rock Edicts: Inscribed on the frontiers of Ashoka's territory and not in the heartland (capital) of the

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 48

45

Cave Architecture

y Background: Earliest Indian rock-cut caves began in Mauryan period in Bihar (Barabar; Nagarjuni; Rajgir) under Ashoka

and Dasaratha; mainly dedicated to Ajivika sect and Buddhism.

y Salient Features: Mirror-like Mauryan polish; simple geometric plans; stone imitation of wooden architecture; plain

interiors with decorated entrances (notably Lomas Rishi).

y Barabar Hills: Four caves – Lomas Rishi (finest); Sudama (earliest); Viswamitra (plain); Karna Chopar (used for monsoon

retreat/Vassavasa).

y Nagarjuni Hills: Three caves – Gopi ka Kubha (largest polished chamber); Vadathi ka Kubha; Vapiya ka Kubha; donated

by Dasaratha to Ajivika monks.

y Swarna Bhandar; Rajgir: Associated with Jainism and Ajivika; shows inferior Mauryan polish; trapezoidal entrance and

pointed ceiling; contains Gupta-period inscriptions.

Sculpture

y Didarganj Yakshini (Bihar)

• Tall, well-proportioned sculpture.

• Made of sandstone with a polished surface.

• Exhibits happiness and bounty.

• Chauri (flywhisk) is held in the right hand.

y Dhauli Elephant (Orissa)

• Carved in the living rock.

• Includes Sevto (white) in Pali, suggesting Airavat, a white elephant in Indian religious texts.

• Situated close to the battleground where Ashoka decided to shift away from warfare and towards

Buddhism.

Stupas

y Stupas: Originally burial mounds prevalent in India from Vedic period

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 49

46

Mudrarakshasa y Written by Vishakhadatta, later in 5th Century, Gupta period

y Details how Chanakya helped Chandragupta overthrow the Nandas.

Megasthenes's Indica y Talks about the nature of the economy and society of the Mauryan period.

Other parallel

Literary works under

different regimes

y Rajtrangini by Kalhana; Mahabhashya by Patanjali

y Buddhist literature: Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa; Divyavadana; Ashokavandana;

Mahabodhivamsa; Digghanikaya

y Jain literature: Vasudevcharita and Kalpasutra by Bhadrabahu

Decline of Mauryas

y Several factors led to the decline of the empire:

• Weak successors • political instability

• Over-centralised administration • provincial rebellions

• Breakdown of spy system • corruption, decline in state loyalty

• Famines (especially North Bengal) • economic weakening

• Ashoka's Buddhist patronage • reduced Brahmanical support

• Foreign invasions • pressure from Bactrian Greeks

Post Mauryas

The Post-Mauryan period (185 BCE–300 CE) began with the decline of the Mauryan Empire after Ashoka and was marked by the

rise of regional and foreign-origin dynasties. In north India, indigenous powers like the Shungas, Kanvas, and Chedis emerged,

while the Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Parthians, and Kushanas established control over the north-western regions. Despite the absence

of a pan-Indian empire, the period witnessed intense economic activity, urbanisation, monetisation, long-distance trade, and

cultural interaction, especially through Central Asian and Indo-Roman contacts, making it a crucial transitional phase in ancient

Indian history.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 50

47

Indo-Parthians (Pahlavas) 1st BCE–1st CE

y Origin: Iranian (Parthian) origin from Khorasan region; ruled parallel with Sakas for sometime; replaced them later

y Ruled in NW India with capital in Taxila (Periplus of the Erythraean Sea mentions their rule in Sindh)

y Key rulers:

• Arsaces I of Parthia (founder of Parthian Empire)

• Gondophernes (Founder of the Indo-Parthian Kingdom; mentioned in Takht-i-Bahi inscription)

y Religion: Zoroastrian (ancestral; Jandial Temple); Hinduism (Shiva coins); St. Thomas propagated Christianity; Buddhism

(patronised Gandhara art)

y Administration: Monarchical rule, Feudal officials (Mahakshatrapa, kshatrapas, etc.)

y Economy:

• Trade links (Rome/Parthia)

• Coins of the Hindu deity Shiva with trident issued

• Key player in the Silk Road trade, connecting India, China, and Rome (Chinese explorer Zhang Qian)

y Art and Culture:

• Advanced Greco-Buddhist sculptures

• Figures are depicted in short, crossover jackets adorned with rings or medals, paired with baggy trousers.

Kushanas 1st–3rd CE

y Origin: Yuezhi tribes of Central Asia

y Ruled in NW & North India with Purushapura (Peshawar), Mathura as capitals

y Key rulers: Kujula Kadphises, Kanishka

• Kujula Kadphises – First Kushan king who conquered Afghanistan. H

• Rabatak Inscription relates to Kanishka's genealogy with Kujula Kadphises.

• Kanishka convened the fourth Buddhist council; patronised scholars like Vasumitra, Asvagosha and Nagarjuna.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 51

48

Indigenous North Indian Dynasties

Indigenous North Indian Dynasties

Shungas

(185–73 BCE)

y Founded by Pushyamitra Shunga (assassinated the last Mauryan ruler Brihadratha) –

reasserted Brahmanical political authority.

y Capitals: Pataliputra, later Vidisha

y Features: Revival of Brahmanical traditions; performed Ashvamedha; Decline of state Buddhist

patronage; Repelled Indo-Greek invasions

y Culture: Bharhut Stupa expansion + Malavikagnimitra (Kalidasa) – court life of Agnimitra

Shunga; Manusmriti (Manavadharmashastra) was composed.

y Significance: Transition from Mauryan empire – regional kingdoms; Shift from wooden to

stone structures in Buddhist stupas

Kanvas

(73–28 BCE)

y Kanva Dynasty: Founded by Vasudeva Kanva after overthrowing the Shungas; continued

Brahmanical rule at Pataliputra.

y Nature of Rule: Short-lived, weak political cohesion – decline of Magadha's dominance.

y End: Overthrown by Satavahanas – shift of power from Gangetic plains to Deccan.

Chedi Dynasty –

Kalinga

(1st century BCE)

(King Kharavela)

y The Chedi ruler Kharavela of Kalinga – recorded in the Hathigumpha

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 52

49

Administration y King held supreme authority; titles like Rajan, Maharaja

y Important officials:

â™¦ Maharashtra – provincial governor

â™¦ Gaulmika – military officer in charge of frontier or forest regions

â™¦ Uparakshita – Charged with the duty of building caves for monks

y Administration retained Mauryan influences but adapted to regional needs

y Local autonomy allowed to guilds and religious institutions

y Kataka and Skandhavaras: Military camps and settlements

Economy y Agrarian base supported by trade – Major crops: Rice and Cotton

y Trade: Mentioned by Pliny the Elder as powerful rulers controlling trade routes;

y Major Ports – Sopara, Bharuch, Kalyani, Koddura, Chinnaganjam, Gandakasela, Goa,

Machilipatnam, Dharanikota

y Coins: Issued lead, copper, silver, potin coins; Coins were known as Karshapanas; Roman gold

coins found in Deccan sites

Society and

Religion

y Society showed varna ideals, but with flexibility in practice

y Kings named after their mothers (Gautamiputra Satakarni)

y Land grants to Brahmanas and monasteries became common

y Revival of Brahmanism + coexistence with Buddhism; Donations recorded at Nasik, Karle, Bhaja,

Kanheri; Mahayana Buddhism gained a significant following

Architecture &

Art

y Major patrons of rock-cut architecture

â™¦ Sites: Karle Chaitya (largest rock-cut chaitya hall); Nasik and Bhaja caves; Amaravati Stupa

(Andhra region)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 53

50

Western

Gangas

y Time Period: ~4th century CE – 10th century CE; Early phase overlaps with late Vakatakas & Guptas

y Region: Southern Deccan Karnataka (Gangavadi region); Capital: Talakad (Banks of Kaveri, Mysore)

y Political Origin:

– Konganivarman Madhava (Founder)

– Indigenous Karnataka dynasty (use of Kannada)

– Often feudatories of larger powers like Pallavas, Chalukyas, Rashtrakutas

y Administration: Well-organised local administration (Visaya/Nadu); Strong role of local assemblies

y Religion:

– Major patrons of Jainism (Statue of Gommateshwara (Bahubali))

– Also supported Shaivism and Vaishnavism

y Art & Architecture: Early Dravidian features

Post Maurya Art and Architecture

y Rock-cut Caves: Development of two types of rock caves – Chaitya (prayer halls) and Vihar (residential halls)

y Udayagiri and Khandagiri Caves (Odisha): Under Kalinga King Kharavela in 1st-2nd century BC; famous for

Hathigumpha inscription; in Brahmi script; inscription starts with ‘Jain Namokar Mantra’; Famous for Ranigumpha

cave

y Stupas: Stupas became larger and more decorative; increased use of stone; idea of torans introduced by Shungas

(Hellenistic influence); example: Bharhut Stupa (MP)

y Sculpture: Development of Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati schools

Gandhara, Mathura and Amravati School of Sculpture

Post-Mauryan India witnessed the zenith of sculptural art through the emergence of three prominent regional schools – Gandhara,

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 54

51

Guptas, Post Guptas and Harsha

8

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of [2025]

(a) Samudragupta

(b) Chandragupta II

(c) Kumaragupta I

(d) Skandagupta

2. With reference to the scholars/litterateurs of ancient India, consider the following

statements: [2020]

1. Panini is associated with Pushyamitra Shunga.

2. Amarasimha is associated with Harshavardhana.

3. Kalidasa is associated with Chandra Gupta - II.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only

(b) 2 and 3 only

(c) 3 only

(d) 1, 2 and 3

The Guptas emerged around 320 CE amid post-Kushana political fragmentation and declining Indo-Roman trade, ushering in

an agrarian, land-grant economy. The Gupta dynasty was founded by Sri Gupta (240–280 AD) who was succeeded by

Ghatotkacha (280–319 AD). Ruling till ~550 CE, they marked India's Classical Age, centred in Magadha and the Gangetic

plains, with Pataliputra as capital.

Answers: 1. (b), 2. (c)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 55

52

Key Gupta Rulers

Sri Gupta y Founder of the Gupta lineage.

Chandragupta I

(320–335 CE)

y Real founder of Gupta imperial power (consolidated Gupta power) Titled himself Maharajadhiraja

y Matrimonial alliance with the Lichchavis

y Issued gold coins depicting himself with his queen

Samudragupta

(335–375 CE)

y Military conquests recorded in Allahabad Pillar Inscription composed by Harisena (Mentioned

him as ‘Dharmachakra Prachar Bandhu’); Performed Ashvamedha; Known as ‘Napoleon of India’

y Military policy of:

• Aryavarta (North India) direct annexation (conquest)

• Dakshinapatha (South India) defeated, reinstated, tributary status (subordination)

y Poet-king (Kaviraj); gold coins depict him playing a veena

Chandragupta II

(Vikramaditya)

(376 – 415 CE)

y Peak of territorial expansion; defeated Western Shakas assumed the title Shakari (destroyer of

the Sakas)

y Titles: Simhavikrama and Vikramaditya

y Udaigiri cave inscriptions mentioned his Digvijaya

y Issued silver coins along with gold dinars and copper coins

y Matrimonial alliance between Daughter Prabhavati Gupta and Rudrasena II (Vakataka)

y Navaratnas (traditional attribution):

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 56

53

Gupta Empire Administration

y Central: Blend of centralisation (absolute power with king, hereditary kingship) & decentralisation (Emergence of

samantas system)

y Provincial: Bhukti/ Deshas (Province) → Vishaya (District) → Vithis / Grama (Village)

y Judicial: King (supreme judicial authority) → Maha-danda-nayaka (Chief Justice)

â™| No practice of capital punishment (Fa-Hien); Different courts: Karana, Adhikarana, Aharmasana

y Revenue: Land tax (1/4th to 1/6th of the produce) + Vishti/ Iranyavesti (forced labour as a source of state income)

â™| Bhaga/Bhoga: Customary share of produce paid to the king.

â™| Hiranya: Tax payable in gold coins or certain crops paid in kind.

â™| Sulka: Customs and tolls on merchandise

â™| Halivakara: Plough-share-tax

â™| Kipta: purchase tax/ sales tax

â™| Prataya: Toll Tax

â™| Bhatta: Police Tax

â™| Udakabhag: Water Tax

â™| Taradaya: Tax on navigation

â™| Bedakbhog: Irrigation Tax

â™| Uparnik: Tax taken from border area

â™| Sarvarishti: Forced Tax

y Officials:

â™| Kumaramatya: High-ranking administrative officials

â™| Ayuktaka: Revenue and administrative functions

â™| Mahapratihara: Chief of palace guards

â™| Pratihara: Ceremonial overseer / palace official

â™| Dutaka: Executor and notifier of land grant

â™| Akshapataladhikrita: Keeper of royal records

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 57

54

Gupta Empire Art, Architecture and Literature

("Golden Age")

Art (Sculptures,

pillars, inscriptions)

y Sculpture: Use of cream coloured sandstone and metal; sculptures dressed well; examples â†'

Sultanganj (Bronze) Buddha, Nalanda (Copper) Buddha

y Metallurgy: Mehrauli Iron Pillar (Delhi)

y Paintings: Murals and 3D technique

y Damodarpur plates â†' Mention Uparika with the title of maharaja

y Eran pillar inscription (510 AD) of Budhaguptaâ†' refers to Maharaja Surashmichandra as a

Lokpal; first evidence of sati

y Paharpur Copper Plate Inscriptionâ†' king as sole proprietor of the land

Architecture y Temples: Transition from rock-cut to structural temples â†' Emergence of Nagara style

(Dashavatara Temple (Deogarh, Jhansi), Bhitargaon Temple (Kanpur))

â™| 5 stages: Progression from the flat-roofed, monolithic temples â†' sculptured â€šshikharaâ€™

y Stupas: Decline in the development of stupas; Samat (Sarnath, UP), Ratnagiri (Odisha), and

Mirpur Khas (Sind)

y Caves: Use of mural paintings on cave walls; Examples â†' Ajanta and Ellora (Jataka and courtly

paintings) in MH; Mandapeshwar Caves (Mumbai; Brahmanical cave â†' christian); Bagh caves

(Paintings) in MP and Udayagiri (Varaha avatar) in MP; Junagadh Caves (GJ)

Literature y Buddhist writers: Arya Deva, Arya Asanga, Vasubandhu and Dignaga

y Jain writers: Vimala (wrote Jain version of Ramayana); Siddasena Divakara

y Kalidasa: Dramasâ†' Abhijnanashakuntalam, Malavikagnimitram, Vikramaurvashiyam; Epics/

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 58

55

Major Post-Gupta Dynasties (North & Central India) and Invaders

y Huns: Central Asian invaders – Chiefs Toramana and Mihirakula – Occupied Malwa and Punjab – Accelerated Gupta

decline

y Later Guptas: Remnants of Gupta line in Magadha and Malwa; Engaged in conflicts with Maukharis and Pushyabhutis

y Maukharis: Ruled Agra and Oudh; Capital Kanauj; Acted as a buffer against Huna threats; Later integrated into Harsha's

empire

y Maitrakas: Saurashtra (Gujarat); Capital Valabhi; Major center of learning and trade

y Gauda Kingdom: Bengal; King Shashanka (first prominent independent Bengal ruler); Rival of Harsha; Patron of

Hinduism

Harshavardhana Period (606 – 647 CE)

After the Gupta decline, North India fragmented among the Maitrakas (Valabhi), Maukharis, and Vakatakas. The

Pushyabhutis of Thanesar founded the Vardhana dynasty. Harshavardhana (c. 606–647 CE) rose from the Pushyabhuti,

marking the transition to a feudal age. Centered in the Gangetic Doab with Kanauj as the new imperial capital, his reign

unified North India.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Which of the following phrases defines the nature of the “Hundi”™ generally referred to in

the sources of the post Harsha period? [2020]

- (a) An advisory issued by the king to his subordinates
- (b) A diary to be maintained for daily accounts
- (c) A bill of exchange
- (d) An order from the feudal lord to his subordinates

2. With reference to Indian History, which of the following is/are the essential element/

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 59

56

Harsha's Empire

Harshavardhana y Title: Rajputra, Siladitya; Last great Hindu ruler of North India

y Unified Thanesar and Kanauj – Subjugated Gauda (after Sasanka), Magadha, and Odisha

y Defeated by Pulakeshin II (Chalukya) at the Narmada river – Checked Harsha's southward

advance

y Shifted capital from Thanesar to Kanauj – Strategic middle doab location – Fortified

"Skandhavara" (military camp); Prayag – important city

y Maintained friendly relations with China – contemporary of the Tang emperor, Tai Tsung.

y Hieun Tsang (prince of pilgrims) visited during his period:

– Wrote "Si-Yu-ki" (Buddhist Records of the Western World)

– Spent about five years at the University of Nalanda

– Mention instances of robbery on roads and rivers in his writings

– Carried with him relics of Buddha, Buddha images and manuscripts

– Mentions that tradesmen had to pay duties at ferries and barrier stations

Administration y Nature: More feudal (Samantas – Land owners + hereditary office + military aid to king +

decentralized power – judicial rights) and decentralized than Gupta's

y Structure: Empire – Provinces (Bhuktis) – Districts (Vishayas) – Sub-districts (Pathakas) –

Village

y Key Officials:

– Avanti: Minister for Foreign Relations and War

– Simhananda: Commander-in-Chief

– Kuntala: Chief Cavalry Officer

– Skandagupta: Chief Commandant of Elephant Force

– Dirghadhvaj: Royal Messengers

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 60

57

The Sangam Age

9

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Which one of the following explains the practice of Vattakirutal™ as mentioned in Sangam

poems? [2023]

(a) Kings employing women bodyguards

(b) Learned persons assembling in royal courts to discuss religious and philosophical

matters

(c) Young girls keeping watch over agricultural fields and driving away birds and

animals

(d) A king defeated in a battle committing ritual suicide by starving himself to death

2. Which one of the following statements about Sangam literature in ancient South India

is correct? [2022]

(a) Sangam poems are devoid of any reference to material culture.

(b) The social classification of Varna was known to Sangam poets.

(c) Sangam poems have no reference to warrior ethic.

(d) Sangam literature refers to magical forces as irrational.

The Sangam Age (generally c. 300 BCE–300 CE) marks the early historic phase of Tamil history and derives its name from the

Sangams, the academies of Tamil poets and scholars that promoted literary activity. This period witnessed the flourishing of the

Tamil language and classical literature. According to tradition, there were Three Sangams (Muchchangam), all of which were

patronised by the Pandya rulers, who supported and nurtured Tamil literary culture.

Sangam Place Presided by Surviving Work

First Sangam Ten-Madurai Agastya No extant work

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 61

58

Administration y Hereditary monarchy; Advisory council: Avai

y Divisions: Mandalam + Nadu (province) + Ur (urban city) + Perur (large village) + Sirur

(small village)

y Three levels of ruler: Kizhar (Village leaders + later Nadu chiefs); Velir (Regional chieftains ruling

hilly and forest areas); Vendar (ruled fertile regions)

y Officials:

+ Amaichar (minister)

+ Senathipathi (army chief)

+ Anthanar (priest)

+ Thuthar (envoy)

+ Otrar (spy)

y Military: belonged mainly to the Vellalar class; title of Enadi; Kodimaram + a tutelary tree

representing its army.

y Tax terms:

+ Karai = land tax

+ Ulgu = customs

+ Irai = tribute

+ Variyar = tax collector

+ Iravu = compulsory gifts or additional demands

Economy y Agriculture (Main occupation): Paddy dominant (Chola & Pandya); Pepper famous in Chera land;

Crops: rice, sugarcane, cotton, spices.

y Trade:

+ Internal: Mostly barter; Day & night markets (Maduraikanchi)

+ External: Trade with Rome & Greek kingdoms; Ports: Puhar, Musiri, Tondi, Korkai; Roman

gold coins found; Exports: spices, cotton, pearls; Imports: gold, horses, wine

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 62

59

Art and Culture y Popular arts: Music, dance, Koothu

y Instruments: Yazh (harp)

y Bards: Panar, Viraliyar

Architecture y Limited structural remains

y Hero stones widespread

y Karikala Chola built Kallanai (Grand Anicut) – dam across Kaveri

y Major ports mentioned in Pattinappalai

y KEELADI EXCAVATION (Modern Relevance) – Located on Vaigai river (Tamil Nadu);

Evidence of Urban settlement + Pottery industry + Script use + Weaving & dyeing + Sangam age

possibly earlier than 3rd century BCE

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 63

60

Medieval Regional Kingdoms

and Administration 10

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following events in the history of India: [2020]

1. Rise of Pratiharas under King Bhoja
2. Establishment of Pallava power under Mahendravarman I
3. Establishment of Chola power by Parantaka I
4. Pala dynasty founded by Gopala

What is the correct chronological order of the above events, starting from the earliest

time?

- (a) 2 - 1 - 4 - 3
- (b) 3 - 1 - 4 - 2
- (c) 2 - 4 - 1 - 3
- (d) 3 - 4 - 1 - 2

The Tripartite Struggle

Following the decline of the Pushyabhuti empire, North India transitioned into an era marked by political fragmentation and

the rise of lineage-based warrior clans. While the fertile Gangetic plains were dominated by the Tripartite Struggle for Kannauj

among the Gurjara-Pratiharas, Palas, and Rashtrakutas, distinct independent polities also flourished in the Himalayan

frontiers (Kashmir and Himachal) and the central uplands.

The Tripartite Struggle

The Tripartite Struggle was a prolonged contest among the Gurjara-Pratiharas, Palas, and Rashtrakutas for control over

Kannauj, a strategically important political, economic, and cultural centre on the Ganga trade route.

Reasons: Strategic location on Ganga trade route; Political control over Uttarapatha (North India); Economic gains after

decline of Silk Route

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 64

61

Gurjara- Pratiharas (730–1036 CE)

Originally pastoralists/fighters from Rajasthan; "Pratihara" means "door-keeper" – Lakshmana (Rama's door-keeper) as their hero.

Key Rulers y Nagabhatta I: Real founder; checked Arab invasions; power base at Ujjain

y Vatsaraja (c. 780–800 CE): Engaged in the Tripartite Struggle; made Kannauj his capital; defeated

Dharmapala and Dantidurga but later lost to Dhruva.

y Nagabhatta II (805–833 CE): conquered Kanauj (established capital) – defeated Palas – attacked

Kannauj (conflict with Dharmapala and Rashtrakuta king, Govinda III – defeat of Nagabhatta II)

y Mihir Bhoja (836–885 CE): greatest Pratihara ruler; titled Adivaraha (Vishnu devotee); established his capital at Kannauj,

y Mahendrapala I: Expanded empire but lost Punjab to Kashmir; Patronized the poet Rajashekhar.

Administration y Units: Bhukti (Uparika) – Mandala/Visaya (Visayapati) – Pattala

y Dominance of Bhogapatis/ Samantas in village affairs

Art and

Architecture

y Established architectural foundations at Khajuraho (Nagara style – curvilinear shikharas); open

pavilion style; Vertical Planes (Triratha, pancharatha design), Use of local sandstone

y Examples: Mahavira Jain Temple (Rajasthan); Bateswar Hindu Temples (Madhya Pradesh); Baroli

Temples (Rajasthan)

y Sculpture: Religious iconography (Vishwaroop of Vishnu), Boar (Varaha) incarnation of Vishnu;

Bhoja coins

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 65

62

Architecture y Developed the Vesara style (hybrid of Nagara and Dravida) vimana.

y Ellora Caves: Features monolithic Kailasanath Temple (by Krishna I; Cave 16); carved from a single piece of stone.

y Elephanta Caves: Dashavatara Temple (By Dantidurga; Cave 15) â†’ Hiranyakashipu and Narasimha (Vishnu) sculpture.

y Seals: Featured the Garudavahana (By Krishna I; mount of Vishnu) or Shiva seated in a yogic posture.

Art and

Literature

y Sculpture in Kailasha temple: Ravana shaking Mount Kailasa, Dancing Shiva and Vishnu, and

Lakshmi listening to music

y Sculptures in Elephanta Caves: Maheshamurti (25 ft tall three-faced bust of Shiva), Sadashiva and

Nataraja

y Literature: Poet Pampa (Adipurana in champu style + Vikramarjuna Vijaya); Ponna (Shanti Purana);

Amoghavarsha I (author of Prashnottara Ratnamalika + Kavirajamarga)

Palas (750â€“1161 AD)

y Background: Disruption in Bengal after death of Sasanka â†’ Local chiefs elect Gopala I as the head to end anarchy

(matsya-nyaya) â†’ Pala dynasty established by Gopala I

y Rule: Centered in Bengal and Bihar; major centers included Pataliputra, Vikramapura, Monghyr (Munger), and

Tamralipti

Key Rulers y Gopala I (~750â€“770 CE): First Buddhist king; built monastery at Odantapuri (Bihar).

y Dharmapala (~770â€“815 CE): Zenith of Power (mentioned in Khalimpur copper plate inscription);

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 66

63

The Sena Dynasty

Origin y Migrated from Karnataka (South India); described in the Deopara inscription as Brahma-

Kshatriyas (Brahmins who became warriors)

Key Rulers y Hemanta Sena (c. 1095 CE): usurped power during Pala decline.

y Vijaya Sena (c. 1095 – 1158 CE): Real Founder; expelled the last Pala ruler; maintained dual capitals at

Vikrampur and Vijayapura; commemorated in Sriharsha's Vijay Prasasti and Umapati Dhara's

Deopara Prashasti.

y Ballal Sena (c. 1158 – 1179 CE): Ruled and consolidated five provinces (Banga, Barendra, Rar, Bagri,

Mithila); established Nabadwip as a capital; introduced Kulinism (orthodox social hierarchy) in

Bengal; Composed the Sanskrit works Danasagara and Adbhutsagara.

y Lakshmana Sena (c. 1178 – 1207 CE): Zenith: Expanded suzerainty to Assam (Kamrupa), Odisha, and

Bihar; devout Vaishnav – Titled Paramvaishnava; Patronized Jayadeva (author of Gita Govinda) and

Halayudha (his PM); Ghurid Invasion (c. 1204 CE) – Bakhtiyar Khalji launched a surprise raid on

Nabadwip, forcing him to flee.

Religion y Staunch Hindu rulers (unlike the Buddhist Palas they replaced); initially Shaivite, later shifted to

Vaishnavism

Art and

Architecture

(Pala-Sena

School)

y Structural Innovation: Developed the "Bangla roof" (curved/sloping roofs modeled after bamboo

huts), later adopted by Mughal architects.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 67

64

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following dynasties: [2023]

1. Hoysala
2. Gahadavala
3. Kakatiya
4. Yadava

How many of the above dynasties established their kingdoms in early eighth century

AD?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) Only three
- (d) None

2. Consider the following pairs: [2022]

King Dynasty

1. Nannuka – Chandela
2. Jayashakti – Paramara
3. Nagabhata II – Gurjara-Pratihara
4. Bhoja – Rashtrakuta

How many pairs given above are correctly matched ?

- (a) Only one pair
- (b) Only two pairs
- (c) Only three pairs
- (d) All four pairs

3. The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple

at Veraval. Which of the following statements are correct regarding Somnath Temple?

[2022]

1. Somnath Temple is one of the Jyotirlinga shrines.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 68

65

The Rajputs States

The term Rajput refers to specific lineage-based clans that trace their descent from mythical ancestors to claim Suryavanshi,

Chandravanshi, or Agnikula status. These dynasties share a common martial spirit, a decentralized clan-based social structure,

and a political evolution from feudatories into independent sovereign powers. United by a code of honour and land attachment,

these groups provided regional stability.

The Rajput Dynasties

Tomaras

(8th – 12th CE)

- y Served as feudatories of the Gurjara-Pratiharas

- y Ruled the Haryana region with Dhillika (modern Delhi) as the capital; conflicts with the

Chahamanas of Shakambhari

- y Key Rulers

- Anangapala Tomara (Anangpal II): officially established Delhi; Commissioned citadel of

- Lal Kot in Mehrauli + Anang Tal; built Aligarh Fort

- Surajpala: Constructed of Suraj Kund reservoir (near Faridabad, Haryana)

- y Coins: distinct horseman-and-bull motif; bore the title "Shri Samanta-deva"

- y Responsible for building one of the earliest surviving waterworks in the Delhi area

- y Got incorporated into the Chauhan kingdom in 1161 AD.

Chahamanas/

Chauhans

(7th–12th CE)

- y Originally feudatories of the Gurjara-Pratiharas; Agnikula origin

- y Based in Rajasthan – Shakambhari (Sambhar) + later Ajayameru (Ajmer), with early capitals

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 69

66

Solanki

(Chalukyas of Gujarat)

(950 – 1300 CE)

They ruled over Gujarat and Kathiawar; Capital: Anahilapataka (modern Patan, Gujarat)

Key Rulers

↳ Mularaja I (c. 940–995 CE): Dynasty founder; Shaivite; built the Mulavasatika temple

(Digambaras) + Mulanatha-jinadeva temple (Shvetambaras).

↳ Bhima I (c. 1022–1064 CE): Somnath temple plundered by Mahmud of Ghazni in 1025

CE during his reign; Commissioned Modhera Sun Temple; Minister Vimalsha's Vimal

Vasahi temple dedicated to Rishabha at Mount Abu (Dilwara Temples)

↳ Karan (c. 1065–1091 CE): Founded Karnavati (Ahmedabad).

↳ Jayasimha Siddharaja (c. 1092–1142 CE): Annexed Saurashtra, Kutch, and Malwa.

Junagadh Siege's Sati by Ranakdevi at Wadhwan; patronized Jain monk Hemachandra

+ built the Rudra Mahakala Temple.

↳ Kumarapala (c. 1142–1171 CE): Rebuilt Somnath temple; patronized Jainism.

↳ Bhima II (c. 1177–1240 CE): Defeated Ghori in Battle of Kayadara (near Mt. Abu) in

1178/1179 CE + Defeated Qutb-ud-din Aibak's titled "Abhinav Siddharaj"

Architecture:

↳ Maru-Gurjara style's step-tank (Suryakund) near temples + Decorated Torans;

Temple walls lacked external carvings, but intricate wooden-style carvings in stone;

Designed so sun rays hit the central shrine during equinoxes; used sandstone, black

basalt, and soft marble.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 70

67

Bundela Dynasty

(16th-19th century)

y Bundela polity evolved from local chieftains to major regional sovereigns by the 16th AD.

y Bundelkhand region comprises present-day Madhya Pradesh & Uttar Pradesh with principal centres:

Orchha (on the Betwa River), Panna, Chanderi, Kalinjar, Mahoba, Jaitpur, Datia, etc.

y Key Rulers (Orchha state)

â™| Rudra Pratap Bundela: laid the foundation of a new city called Orchha

â™| Bharti Chand: shifted capital to Orchha; built Orchha fort, Raj Temple, Rani palace, and

Saharpanah.

â™| Veer Singh Deo Bundela built Jahangir Palace at Orchha + Sawan Bhadon Mahal.

Later kings became Mansabdars under Mughals.

y Key Rulers (Panna state): Maharaja Chhatrasal Bundela (c. 1671–1731): Declared Panna

as capital; rebellion against Mughal governorsâ†' called upon Peshwa Baji Rao I under pressure

from Muhammad Khan Bangash (Mughal)

y Architecture: Orchha complex (UNESCO WHS); Pratapgarh Fort (Datia), Talbethat Fort

(Lalitpur, UP)

Kachchhapaghata

Dynasty

(10th–12th CE)

y Ruled north-western Madhya Pradesh (Gwalior, Morena, Narwar, Dubkunda); feudatories of

Gurjara-Pratiharas, later Chandelas; gained independence post-Chandela king Vidyadhara's

death (1035 CE) amid Ghaznavid invasions

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 71

68

Chalukyas of Badami (c. 6th–8th Century CE)

Background Originated as vassals of Kadambas (from copper-plate records) → Became independent after Kadamba

decline

Key Rulers y Pulakeshin I: Founder; fortified Badami; Founded Vatapi; Performed Ashvamedha; Followed Vedic

religion; Inscriptions: Badami rock, Amminabhavi stone

y Kirtivarman I: Defeated Nalas, Kadambas, Mauryas of Konkan → night of doom (Aihole

Inscription); Annexed Goa (Revatidvipa)

y Pulakeshin II (c. 610 – 642 CE):

→ Titles → Dakshinapatheshvara, Maharajadhiraja, Parameswara and Sathyasraya (Abode of Truth)

→ Mentioned by Hiuen Tsang as ruler of “Mo-ho-la-cha” (Maharashtra)

→ Defeated Harshavardhana (AD 630) → Aihole inscription

→ Conflict with Pallavas → Victory at Pullalur (618–19 AD) + Defeated & killed at Vatapi

(642 AD) by Narasimhavarman I

→ Foreign relations: Sassanian Persia (Ajanta Cave 1 painting)

→ Ravikirti, his court poet composed Sanskrit prashasti (Aihole Inscription)

Administration,

Economy,

Religion

y Administration: Vijaya Bhattacharya → women as provincial governors + issued inscriptions.

y Religion: Supported Vedic religion (Ashvamedha), Shaivism, and Jainism → Buddhism declining

(Hiuen Tsang)

y Economy weak: Rocky land → low revenue; Frequent wars & plunder

Art and

Architecture

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 72

69

Society and

Religion

y Rise of Veerashaivism (Lingayat movement); Women's participation notable (Akkadevi's administrator

Sovala Devi's patron); Practices' Widowhood accepted, Sati voluntary; Sallekhana among Jains

Art and

Architecture

y Art: Metal and stone sculpture' Dwarapala image looted by Rajendra I, Shiva, Vishnu, and Jain

Tirthankara; Coins featuring Varaha (boar)

y Architecture (Gadag Style): Style' Vesara / Karnatakadravida; Transitional from Badami Chalukya

' Hoysala; Region: Krishna's Tungabhadra doab;

' Features: Soapstone (chloritic schist) as material; Lathe-turned pillars Pushkarni (stepped

wells); stellate (star-shaped) ground plan

' Important Temples: Mahadeva Temple (Itagi); Kasi Vishveshvara Temple (Lakkundi);

Mallikarjuna Temple (Kuruvatti); Kedareshwara Temple (Balligavi); Dodda Basappa (Dambal);

Kalleshwara (Bagali); Siddesvara (Haveri)

y Literature:

' Kannada: Ranna's Gadayuddha, Ajitha Purana; Nagavarma II's Kavyavalokana, Karnataka-

Bhashabhushana; Vachana writers: Basavanna, Akka Mahadevi, Allama Prabhu

' Sanskrit: Bilhana's Vikramankadevacharita; Someshwara III's Manasollasa; Vijjaneshwara's

Mitakshara (Hindu law)

Kakatiyas (c. 12th-14th CE)

y Ruled Telangana, between Krishna and Godavari, with capital initially in Hanamakonda ' later Warangal (Orugallu);

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 73

70

Kalachuri Dynasty (Chedis of Tripuri) (9th – 12th CE)

y Ruled Chedi region (Dahala-mandala) – between Narmada and Godavari rivers.

y Originally feudatories of Gurjara-Pratiharas, asserted independence in mid-10th CE.

y Capitals: Tripuri (Jabalpur, MP); secondary branch in South Kosala; capital at Tummana.

y Rulers:

– Kokkala I (c. 845–885 CE): Founder; Married Chandella princess; aided Rashtrakuta Krishna II against the Eastern

Chalukyas and Pratiharas.

– Yuvaraja (c. 915–945 CE): Expelled Rashtrakuta forces; Poet Rajasekara's drama Viddhasalabhanjika celebrates

Yuvaraja's victory.

– Gangeya-deva (c. 1019–1040 CE): Zenith: escaped raids of Mahmud of Ghazni; Titled Trialingadhipati (Lord of the

three Kalingas) and Vikramaditya.

– Lakshmi-Karna (c. 1041–1073 CE): One of the greatest generals of his time; defeated Pandyas, Pallavas, and

Someshvara I.

y Art: Coins featured four-armed; Lakshmi seated cross-legged on a lotus.

y Architecture: Nagara-style variants; Triyatana Temple (Karna Mandir) – three shrines upon a single high platform,

facing different directions, Saptaratha (seven-projection) plan; Keshavanarayana Temple

y Decline: Chalukyan and Chandellas invasions, Paramaras plundered their capital – absorbed by Yadavas of Devagiri,

Ganpatis of Warangal, and Vaghela Rajputs

Major Medieval Kingdoms of North India

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Which one of the following is a work attributed to playwright Bhāsa?
[2024]

(a) Kavyaalankara

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 74

71

Major Kingdoms of Southern India

Pandyas (3rd BCE – 14th CE)

About y Occupied the southernmost Indian peninsula (Pandymandalam), centered in the Vaigai and

Tamiraparni river basins; Capitals: Early capital at Korkai (pearl fishery center) – later

Madurai (also called Kudal); Dynastic Insignia: Fish.

y Early Mentions: Ashoka's Rock Edict II (neighbor ruler); Megasthenes (famous for pearls;

matriarchal influence).

y Royal Titles: Kudalkon, Kudal Nagar Kavalan, Pandiyatirasan, Thennavan

Early/Sangam

Pandyas

(c. 3rd BCE – 3rd CE)

y Vadimbambaninra (Nediyon): The earliest known king

y Nedunchezhiyan: Victor of the Battle of Talaiyalanganam (2nd BCE Mangulam Tamil-Brahmi

inscription)

y Mudukudumi Peruvazhuthi: Issued coins with his name to commemorate performing many

Vedic sacrifices (8th-century Velvikkudi plates)

Pandya Revival

(c. 600 – 920 CE)

y Kadungon: Liberated Pandya by uprooting Kalabhras (late 6th century).

y Arikesari Maravarman (624–674 CE): Contemporary of Mahendravarman I and

Narsimhavarman I; identified as "Kun Pandian" (persecutor of Jains) – converted to Saivism

by saint Thirugnana-sambandar.

y Jatila Parantaka Nedunjadayan (Varaguna I): Greatest ruler; donor of Velvikkudi copper

plates (756–815 CE).

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 75

72

Economy, Society and

Religion

y Maritime Trade with Rome (exports: pearls, spices, gems); later brisk horse trade with Arabs

recorded by Wassaff; Kudirai-chetti: horse trading merchants

â™¦ Trader names â†’Nikamattor, Nanadesi, Ticai-Ayiratu-Ainutruvar, Ainutruvar, Manikiramattar and Patinen-Vishyattar.

y Kayalpattinam (Kayal): Busiest port on the east coast (Marco Polo: full of ships from Arabia

and China)

y Currency: Gold coins termed Kasu, Pon; early coinsâ†’square+elephant motifs; later coins

featured fish.

y Irrigation: Highly advanced; tanks named after royalty (e.g., Tirumaleri)

y Society and Culture: Marco Poloâ†’practice of Sati, polygamy, and the king's immense jewel-

laden wealth.

y Religion: Jainism â†’ Saivism and Vaishnavism; patronized Bhakti movement

y Land Classification:

â™¦ Nattar â€” Assessed land quality for taxation

â™¦ Salabogam â€” Land granted for schools

â™¦ Tattarkani â€” Land assigned to ironsmiths

â™¦ Taccu-maniyam â€” Land assigned to carpenters

â™¦ Bhattavritti â€” Land grant to Brahmin groups for education

Art and Architecture y Architecture: Rock-cut Cave (Sittannavasal (fresco paintings), Kalugumalai (Jain sculptures),

and Pillayarpatti; Expanded existing temples (e.g., Meenakshi temple in Madurai) with massive

ornamented pillars and gopurams

y Sendan Maran inscription â†’ mentions a sluice installed by Pandya to distribute the water

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 76

73

Key Rulers y Vishnugopa (c. 350 A.D.): Defeated by Samudragupta during his South Indian campaign (Allahabad

Pillar Inscription)

y Shivaskandavarman: Referred as “Agnisttomavajapeyasvamedhayaji” in Hirahadagalli plates (one

who conducted the Agnistoma, Vajapeya and Asvamedha sacrifices).

y Simhavishnu (c. 575–600 CE): Founder of later Pallavas – displaced Kalabhras – conquered up to

Kaveri. Titled Avanisimha (Lion of the Earth)

y Mahendravarman I (c. 590–630 CE): Titled Chitrakarapuli (Tiger among the painters), Gunabhara

(Virtuous), Chattakari (Temple builder), Vichitrachitta (Curious-minded); Wrote Mathavilasa

Prahasanam (Sanskrit); Introduced rock-cut temples (Mandapas); from Jainism to Shaivism by the

saint Appar.

– Defeated by Chalukyan ruler Pulekshin II

y Narasimhavarman I / Mahamalla (c. 630–668 CE): Greatest Ruler – Avenged father by defeating

Pulakeshin II – Titled Vatapikonda (Conqueror of Vatapi); Developed Mahabalipuram port +

monolithic Seven Rathas; Husen Tsang visited Kanchi

y Parameshvaraman I (c. 670–695 CE): Called Ugradanda and the “destroyer of the city of Ranarasika

(Kuram copper plates)

y Narasimhavarman II / Rajamalla (c. 700–728 CE): Transition from rock-cut to structural stone

temples (e.g., Shore Temple, Kailashnatha); dispatched embassy to China.

y Nandivarman III (c. 846–869 CE): Defeated Pandyas at the Battle of Sripurambiyam.

y Aparajita (c. 880–893 CE): Last Pallava king – killed by Aditya I (Chola) – end of dynastic rule

Administration y Division: Mandalam – Nadu – Sthala – Grama

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 77

74

Cheras (3rd BCE – 3rd CE)

About y One of the Muvendar (three crowned kings – Cholas + Pandyas); Two branches: first ruled Vanji and the

second ruled Karur.

y Ruled parts of Kerala and the Kongu region of Tamil Nadu; mentioned in Ashoka's Rock Edict II as

Keralaputras; Capital: Vanji; Royal Emblem: Bow and Arrow

y Pugalur inscription (1st century AD) Mentions three generations of Chera rulers

Rulers y Udiyan Cheral: Contemporary of Satavahana King Satakarni II

y Nedunjeral Adan: Titled Adhiraja – defeated seven crowned kings; defeated Yavanas (titled

– Elmayavaramban); Suppressed piracy on the Malabar coast

– His son Ilango Adigal authored the – Silappadikaram.

y Cheran Senguttuvan (The Red or Good Chera): The greatest Chera king (Sangam poets); contemporary

to Yagnasri Satakarni of Satavahanas; North Indian expedition to bring a stone from the Himalayas for

the Kannagi (Goddess of Chastity) idol; introduced Pattini Cult; initiated the first diplomatic mission to

China from South India

Other

Aspects

y Economy: Major Ports – Musiri (Muchiri) and Tondi (Indo-Roman Trade); Exports – pepper

(Yavanapriya), spices, ivory, gemstones, and pearls; Industrial Center for gemstones and carnelian

beads: Kodumanal; Issued copper and lead coins with bow and arrow motif

y Literature: Patitrupathu (information on eight Chera kings); Silappathikaram; Pugalur inscriptions

(near Karur – three generations of Cheras)

UPSC Prelims PYQs

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 78

75

Administration y King venerated on par with God (Chakkaravarti) – advised by Rajagurus (Brahmin preceptors);

Division: Mandalams – Valanadus/Kottams – Nadu – Ur;

y Taniyurs (very large village administered as a single unit; Assemblies: Ur (tax-paying locals); Sabha

(Brahmadeya settlements); Nagaram (Mercantilesa) ; Nattar (landholders); Agraharam: Brahmin

villages

y Tankurrams: Autonomous administration for town and townships

y Electoral System – The Kudavolai (pot-ticket) system (Uttaramerur) – committee members based

on qualifications (property, age, Vedic knowledge)

y Committees (Variyams) – Samvatsara, Eri, Thotta, etc. (Alunganattar – Executive Committee)

y Military: Cavalry – Kudirai Sevagar; Elephants – Anaiyatka; Bowmen – Villaligal; Royal troops –

Velaikkarar

– Padaividu - Cantonments in the capital city; Nilai padai - Military outposts in the conquered

territory; Dandanayagam- commander-in-chief; Perundanam- upper rank in the army;

Cirudanam - lower rank; Velaikkaran- Emperor's personal bodyguards

Economy,

Society &

Religion

y Agriculture: Major revenue source; Land tax (Kadamai) assessed at 1/6th of produce – collected by

department (Puravuvarti-tinaikkalam); Taxes – Irai, Kadamai, Kudimai; Units – Veli, Ma, Kuli (Paddy

unit: Kalam);

y Irrigation: Extensive tank & canal system; Vativaykkal (criss-cross channels – Vati – Drainage

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 79

76

Bhakti and Sufi Movement

11

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. The world's second tallest statue in the sitting pose of Ramanuja was inaugurated by the

Prime Minister of India at Hyderabad recently. Which one of the following statements

correctly represents the teachings of Ramanuja? [2022]

- (a) The best means of salvation was devotion
- (b) Vedas are eternal, self-existent and wholly authoritative
- (c) Logical arguments were essential means for the highest bliss
- (d) Salvation was to be obtained through meditation

2. Consider the following statements: [2019]

- 1. Saint Nimbarka was a contemporary of Akbar.
- 2. Saint Kabir was greatly influenced by Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

3. With reference to cultural history of India, consider the following statements: [2018]

- 1. Most of the Tyagaraja Kritis are devotional songs in praise of Lord Krishna.
- 2. Tyagaraja created several new ragas.
- 3. Annamacharya and Tyagaraja are contemporaries.
- 4. Annamacharya kirtanas are devotional songs in praise of Lord Venkateshwara.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 3 only
- (b) 2 and 4 only

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 80

77

Bhakti Movement

y Origin: The movement originated in South India against the dominance of Brahmanism, in the form of two main groups:

Nayanars and Alvars – used vernaculars Tamil + Telugu

y Evolution: Genesis in South India (6th–10th Century CE) – Philosophical Transition (11th–12th Century CE) – Spread to

North India (13th–15th Century CE) – Regional Spread and Later phase (15th–20th Century CE)

y Features: Monotheism; Devotion over rituals; Equality and social reform; universal brotherhood; simplicity in life; no

superstition practices

y Concept of god – Saguna Bhakti (Devotion to a deity with form) + Nirguna Bhakti (devotion to formless deity); salvation

through devotion

y Bhakti Music: Bhajan – Revolve around the lives of deities or epics like the Mahabharata and Ramayana; Primary

instruments – chimta, dholak, dafli, and manjira.

Alvars

(Vishnu Devotees)

y 12 Vaishnava poet-saints who sang praises of Vishnu/Krishna.

y Notable Saints: Andal (the only female Alvar – "Meera of the South"), Nammalvar (the greatest

Alvar), Periyalvar, and Thondaradippodi.

y Core Text: Nalayira Divya Prabandham ("Tamil Veda"); Tiruppavai By Andal

Nayanar

(Shiva devotees)

y 63 Shaivite saints devoted to Lord Shiva

y Notable Saints: Appar, Sambandar, Sundarar (the trio), Manickavasagar (Composed

Tiruvachakam), and Karaikkal Ammeiyar (female saint who adopted extreme asceticism)

y Core Text: Tevaram (collection by the trio) and Thiruvavasagam.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 81

78

Bhakti Saints in South India

y Adi Shankaracharya (788-820 AD):

â™| Theory of Advaita Vedanta (NonDualism) â†' Brahma Satyam, Jagat Mithya (Brahman is the only truth, the world is

illusory)â†' Individual soul (Atman) is identical to Brahma

â™| Propounded Jnanamargaâ†' moksha is achieved through direct experiential knowledge of the self, rather than actions

or devotion alone.

â™| Literary work: Upadesasahasri, Vivekachudamani, and Bhaja Govindum Stotra.

y Ramanuja (1017â€“1137 AD): Proponent of Vishishtadvaita (qualified non-dualism); challenged the monist ideology of Adi

Sankara; advocated social inclusivity and Vishnu Bhakti; devotion as best means for salvation; world's second tallest statue

at Hyderabad

y Madhvacharya (1238â€“1317 AD): Critic of Adi Shankaracharya's Advaitavada theoryâ†' Advocated of Dvaita philosophy

(dualism) â†' â€œDistinction between the individual soul (jiva) and the supreme reality, Vishnu (Brahman)â€•; According to him,

salvation is only possible through God's grace.

y Annamacharya (1408â€“1503 AD): Andhra Pradesh (Tirumala); worshipped Lord Venkateswara (a form of Vishnu) â†' first

known composer of Carnatic music, Sankirtana â†' "Grandfather of Telugu Song-writing".

y Vallabhacharya (1479-1531 AD):

â™| Born in Andhra, lived in Varanasi, and majorly preached in Rajasthan-Gujarat.

â™| Founder of Pushtimarg (path of grace), devotion to the Krishna through Vatsalya Bhakti

â™| Set up Nathpanthi sect centered at Nathdwara, Rajasthan; propounded the theory of Shuddadvaita (pure non-

dualism); Advocated householdership for Vaishnava devotees.

â™| Established the Rudra Sampradaya school

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 82

79

Bhakti Saints in Western India (Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan)

y Jnaneshwara (1275–1296 AD): Wrote Jnanesvari (Marathi commentary on Gita).

y Janabai (1258-1350 AD): Sudra maid servant of Namdev; composed 300 devotional abhangas

y Namdev (1270–1350 AD): verses included in Guru Granth Sahib; Devoted to Vithoba of Pandharpur (Varkari sect)

y Eknath (1533 – 1599 AD): Wrote Bharood (folk songs) + commented on Bhagavata Purana; central to Varkari movement

y Tukaram (1608–1649 AD): Contemporary of Shivaji; famous for Abhangas; central to Varkari movement

y Sai Baba: Syncretic saint blending Hindu-Muslim devotion (Nasik-Malwa region) – Late 19th–early 20th c: lived in

Shirdi mosque (Dwarkamai); Revered as an incarnation of Lord Dattatreya; taught Shraddha (faith) + Saburi (patience);

popularized bhakti across castes/religions.

y Samarth Ramdas (1608–1681 AD): Wrote Dasabodha; spiritual guide to Shivaji.

y Narsinh Mehta (Gujarat): 15th c, "Adikavi" of Gujarat; wrote "Vaishnava jana"

y Mirabai (Rajasthan): 16th c; devotee of Krishna; daughter-in-law of Rana Sanga.

y Dadu Dayal (Gujarat/Rajasthan): 16th-century Nirguna saint; believed follower of Akbar; founded the Dadupanth

Bhakti Saints in Eastern India (Bengal, Chhatisgarh & Assam)

y Chaitanya Mahaprabhu (Bengal): Popularized Sankirtan (group devotional singing/dancing) for Lord Krishna (Gaudiya

Vaishnavism); Philosophy: Achintya Bheda Abheda – blend of Dvaita + Advaita (simultaneously one with and yet

different from God)

– Teachings recorded in Chaitanya Charitamrita (by Krishnadasa Kaviraja) and Chaitanya Bhagavata (by Vrindavan Das

Thakur)

y Sankaradeva (Assam): Propagated Ekasarana Dharma (devotion to one God,

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 83

80

Chishti y Established by Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti (Ajmer); Prominent figures: Qutubuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki,

Baba Farid (Fariduddin Ganjshakar), Nizamuddin Auliya (opposed Sultan Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq),

Nasiruddin Mahmud (Chirag-e-Dilli)

y Muhammad bin Tughlaq – first Sultan to visit the shrine of Khwaja Muinuddin

y Nizamuddin Auliya's teachings compiled in "Fawaidul Fawad" by Amir Hassan Sizzi. (Also known as

Mehboob-e-Ilahi)

y Believed in simplicity, poverty, and rejected state grants; inclusive of all religions; Used Hindawi;

Practices Ziyarat; shrine of Khwaja Muinuddin (Gharib Nawaz) is most revered

Suhrawardi y Founder – Shihabuddin Suhrawardi – Introduced in India by in Punjab & Sindh; Prominent figures:

Hamid-ud-Din Nagori

y Accepted state grants and maintenance from Sultans, active in politics; Sufis should own property and

knowledge to serve the poor better

Naqshbandi y Established by Khwaja Bahauddin Naqshbandi; Prominent: Ahmad Sirhindi (titled 'Mujaddid' or

reformer of the new millennium)

y Orthodox and radical; opposed Sama; hostile towards Shia and Hindus (opposed withdrawal of Jaziya)

Qadariya y Established by Shah Namatullah; Prominent: Miyan Mir, Dara Shikoh

y Supported Wahdat al-Wajud; dismissed orthodox elements, ritualistic belief

Shattari y Established by Sheikh Sirajuddin Abdullah Shattar; Prominent: Tansen

y promotes self-affirmation, opposite to fana (destruction of ego); incorporated yogic practices

Firdausia y Emerged as a branch of Kubrawiya order, emphasizing a balance between Sharia (Islamic law) and

Tariqa (mystical path).

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 84

81

Delhi Sultanate

12

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements: [2021]

1. It was during the reign of Iltutmish that Chengiz Khan reached the Indus in pursuit

of the fugitive Khwarezm prince.

2. It was during the reign of Muhammad bin Tughluq that Taimur occupied Multan

and crossed the Indus.

3. It was during the reign of Deva Raya II of the Vijayanagara Empire that Vasco da

Gama reached the coast of Kerala.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only

(b) 1 and 2

(c) 3 only

(d) 2 and 3

The arrival of the Arabs and Turks between the 8th and 12th centuries marked the first phase of Islamic military and

political expansion into the Indian subcontinent in the form of recurrent invasions (raids and plundering). These invasions

weakened regional Indian powers, familiarised Turks with Indian polity and routes, and transformed raids into permanent

territorial control, culminating ultimately in the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate. It started with the Second Battle of

Tarain (1192 CE) and ended with the First Battle of Panipat (1526 CE).

Early Medieval Invasions

Muhammad Bin

Qasim (712 CE)

y 1st Islamic invasion; Sent by Governor of Iraq (Umayyad Caliphate);

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 85

82

Key Rulers

Qutb-ud-din

Aibak

(1206–1210)

↳ Viceroy of Muhammad Ghori who founded the Mamluk line; known as Lakh Baksh
↳ Founded

Slave dynasty with Lahore as capital

↳ Imposed Jizya (tax) on non-Muslims for the first time

↳ Started construction of Qutb Minar, Built Quwwat-ul-Islam Mosque (Delhi) & Adhai din ka

Jhopra (Ajmer); Literature ↳ Tabakat-i Nasiri by Minhaj-i-Siraj

↳ Military General Bakhtiyar Khilji destroyed Nalanda, Vikramshila and Odantapuri universities

↳ Died in an accident playing Chaugan (Polo)

Shams-ud-din

Iltutmish

(1210–1236)

↳ Real consolidator; Son-in-law of Aibak ↳ belonged to the Ilbari tribe;
↳ Shifted the capital from Lahore

to Delhi

↳ Recognition: In 1229, the Caliph of Baghdad officially recognized his rule

↳ Organized Corps of Forty (Chalisa/Turkan-e-Chihalgani/Shamsi Bandagan)

↳ Introduced Tanka (silver) & Jital (copper) coins; Formal introduction of Iqta system (land grants in

lieu of salary; non-hereditary but became hereditary under Firuz Shah Tughlaq)

↳ Mongols (Chengiz Khan) reached the Indus in 1221 pursuing Jalaluddin Mangbarni ↳ Iltutmish

↳ diplomatically refused Mangbarni refuge, saving Delhi from Mongols

Raziya Sultana

(1236–1240)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 86

83

Khalji Dynasty (1290–1320 CE)

After the death of Balban in 1287, his inefficient grandson Kaiqubad (1287–1290) succeeded him but was assassinated

by Jalaluddin Khalji, who founded the Khalji Dynasty. The Khalji Dynasty (1290–1320 CE), composed of Afghanized

Turks, marked a departure from the "Slave" regime, transitioning to a period of aggressive territorial expansion and

radical socio-economic experiments.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:
[2022]

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.

2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and

besieged the city.

3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to

Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct ?

(a) 1 and 2

(b) 2 only

(c) 1 and 3

(d) 3 only

Key Rulers

Jalal-ud-din

Khalji

(1290–1296)

y Founder; Faced opposition for ethnicity – did not exclude the Turks from high offices – ended

monopoly of turk high offices.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 87

84

Empire under Khalji Dynasty

Administration y Central: Sultan disregarded theological prescriptions +
Deprived nobles of accumulated wealth + Use

of extensive intelligence network

y Local: Curbed traditional powers and privileges of village officers
(Chaudhuris/Khots)

y Land Administration: Ala-ud-din first Sultan to order land measurement,
Zabti (Biswa as unit) +

Fixed land revenue (Kharaj) at 50% of the produce; introduced Khalisa (Lands
under the Sultan's

direct control to pay personal troops)

y Revenue Collection: Land tax directly from cultivators + Tax pressure on
the rich

y Barid (intelligence officers) and Munhiyans (spies) for monitoring +
Severe punishments for fraud

y Coinage: Issued copper coins and silver Tankas

Art,

Architecture

and Literature

Alai Darwaza by Ala ud-din Khilji

(gateway to Quwwat-ul-Islam Mosque) –

first true dome in India; made of red

sandstone and white marble Siri Fort by Alauddin – By Alfor garrison purpose

y Architecture features: Seljuk style; use of red sandstone; prominence of
Arcade style; Mortar began

to be used prominently

y Amir Khusrau (patronized by Alauddin) – known as the "Parrot of India,"
– wrote Khazain Ul

Futuh + created the Sabaq-i-Hind (Indian style) and introduced ragas like
Ghora and Sanam

y Jayasi's Padmavat (Not written during Khilji period): Written under
patronage of Sher Shah

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 88

85

Key Rulers

Ghiyas-ud-din

Tughlaq

(1320–1324)

y Founder (belonged to the Qarauna tribe of Turks); First sultan to start irrigation works

y Built the fortress-city of Tughlaqabad; Jahaz Mahal in Mandu (Madhya Pradesh); Conquered

Warangal and Bengal

Muhammad

Bin Tughlaq

(MBT)

(1324–1351)

y Also known as Jauna Khan; Moroccan traveller Ibn-Batuta served as his envoy to China

y Reversed policy of Alauddin Khalji – Patronised Hindus and Jain scholars (Jinaprabha Suri)

– Ordered the construction of a new Basadi upasraya, a rest-house for Jain monks

– First Sultan to have participated in the festival of Holi

y Known for bold, failed experiments:

– Transfer of Capital from Delhi to Daulatabad (Devagiri) – Failed

– Introduced Token Copper Currency – led to mass counterfeiting – reversal in 1329

– Increased taxation in Ganga-Yamuna doab during famine

– Khorasan and Qarachill expedition – later disbanded it

– Established the Diwan-i-Amir Kohi (agriculture department) to provide credit (Takkavi and

Sondhar) to peasants during famines

– Built the fort of Adilabad and the city of Jahanpanah.

– First Sultan to attempt to formulate an agricultural policy for promoting

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 89

86

Literature y Feroz Shah Tughlaq: Futuhat-e-firozshahi (memoir/autobiography)

y Ziauddin Barani: Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi – vital source for the Sultanate up to Firuz Tughlaq; and

Futwa-i-Jahandari

y Amir Khusrav: Tughlaq Nama – detailed poetic account of Ghiyas-ud-din Tughlaq's rise to power.

y Abdul Malik Isami: Futuh-us-Salatin – poetic history of Muslim rule from the Ghaznavids to MBT

y Ibn Batuta: Safarnama Rehla; visited during reign of Muhammad Bin Tughlaq

y Rag Darpan: A Sanskrit musical work translated into Persian under royal patronage

Sayyid Dynasty (1414–1451 CE)

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to Indian history who of the following were known as – Kulah-Daran?

[2022]

- (a) Arab merchants
- (b) Qalandars
- (c) Persian calligraphists
- (d) Sayyids

The Sayyid Dynasty marked a phase of sharp territorial contraction and political transition after Timur's invasion of

1398, characterized by tributary subordination (vassal status) to the Timurids and the steady reduction of imperial

authority to the city of Delhi alone.

• Claimed to be descendants of Prophet Muhammad; Known as Kulah-Daran (distinctive pointed religious caps).

• Rulers: Khizr Khan (founder; appointee of Timur; most competent) – Mubarak Shah – Muhammad Shah – Alam

Shah (voluntarily abdicated the throne).

• Coins were struck in the name of Timur.

• Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi (by Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi) – primary

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 90

87

Empire Under Lodi Dynasty

Architecture y Extensive use of grey and yellow sandstones (marble used sparingly); Large-scale use of mortar and

lime cement; Only tombs were commissioned + introduction of double domes

y Tombs: Octagonal (Sikandar Lodi's Tomb) /square plans (Shish Gumbad), double domes (Bara

Gumbad Mosque), Indo-Islamic syncretism with chhatris/chhajjas; pioneered enclosed gardens or

charbagh-style (Sikandar Lodi's Tomb)

y Mosques: Features stucco work, bracket-lintel blend (Moth ki Mosque)

y Stepwells: Rajon ki Baoli (Sikandar Lodi era)

Art y Arabesque calligraphy inscribing Quranic verses; Floral and Geometrical carvings; absence of human

and animal figures

y Sufi practice of Sama (musical recitation); use of Rabab and Sarangi

Literature y Sikander Lodi wrote Persian verses under the name ~Gulrakhi™

y Sanskrit remained the language of high intellectual thought

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to medieval India, which one of the following is the correct sequence in

ascending order in terms of size? [2021]

(a) Paragana~Sarkar~Suba

(b) Sarkar~Paragana~Suba

(c) Suba~Sarkar~Paragana

(d) Paragana~Suba~Sarkar

2. Consider the following statements: [2019]

1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the in-charge of revenue collection

was known as ~Amil™.

2. The Iqta system of Sultans of Delhi was an ancient indigenous institution.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 91

88

Economy & Social Life in Delhi Sultanate

y Economy: Agrarian Economy – Based partly on Hanafi law

y Land Categories: Khalisa (direct royal control) + Iqta (assigned to officials) + Inam/Waqf (religious/ charity grants) +

Mawas (areas refusing to pay tax)

y Taxes: Kharaj + Jizya + Mehsul (Teerth Yatra Tax) + Zakat + Khams + Charai + Ghari

y Introduction of new techniques: Manufacturing of paper (learnt from Chinese); Use of iron stirrups and armour;

Introduction of spinning wheels

y Currency System: Pre-Sultanate – scarcity of pure silver; Early coins retained Lakshmi / bull-horseman motifs – called

Dehliwal; Standardised Coinage by Iltutmish and Muhammad bin Tughlaq

y Trade: Foreign trade flourished; Merchant Groups – Karwanis/Nayaks (grain traders) + Multanis (long-distance trade)

y Social Structure: Caste remained dominant; Existence of slavery (Types: Bought in slave markets + War captives)

y Women: Subordinate position of women; existence of sati and Purdha system; Widow had right over property of sonless

husband (if not joint property)

y Marriage: Hindus – Endogamy within sub-caste; inter-varna marriage discouraged; Muslims – Marriage allowed with

status consideration (kafu)

y Religious discrimination: Muslim nobles held high offices; Hindus considered – zimmi – jaziya tax

Architecture

y Development of Indo-Islamic Architecture – Fusion of Persian – Central Asian Islamic style + Indian craftsmanship

y Introduction of Arches, Domes, Tall minarets, decorative Arabic script, use of concrete and mortar

y Geometrical and floral designs (instead of human and animal figures in Hindu temples)

y Khilji Architecture – Arcuate Style established; True arches & true domes;

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 92

89

Hoysalas, Vijaynagara, Bahmani

and Deccan Sultanate Empire 13

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to the history of ancient India, Bhavabhuti, Hastimalla and Kshemeshvara

were famous [2021]

(a) Jain monks

(b) playwrights

(c) temple architects

(d) philosophers

Hoysala Empire (1050-1342 AD)

Hoysalas, originally feudatories of the Western Chalukyas, became independent in the 12th century, establishing a powerful

kingdom in Karnataka (around Mysore). Sala, also known as Nripakama, was the founder of the dynasty. They emerged

as a major military power in South India, reducing the Cholas to a dependent status by the late 12th century. Their rule is

especially noted for architectural transition from rock-cut temples to highly ornate Vesara structural temples.

About the Empire

Political Context y Successors to the Vakatakas and Western Chalukyas (Kalyani); Capital moved from Belur to

Halebidu (Dwarasamudra).

y Rulers:

• Nripa Kama II (1026–1047 CE): Foundation of Hoysala power in Karnataka

• Vinayaditya (1047–1098 CE): Consolidated territory; Strengthened administration

• Ereyanga (1098–1108 CE): Military campaigns; Conflict with Cholas

• Vishnuvardhana (1108–1152 CE): Transformative ruler; Converted from Jainism to

Vaishnavism; Influenced by Ramanujacharya; Marked beginning of distinct Hoysala architecture

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 93

90

Architecture y Culmination of Vesara style (hybrid of Nagara and Dravida)

y Independent style: Karnata Dravida – Influenced by Western Chalukyas

y Used soft soapstone (Chlorite schist); Stellate Plans (star-shaped raised platform (jagati) – ekakuta-

dvikuta-trikuta)

y Multiple shrines built around a central pillared hall

y Designed for clockwise pradakshina; Sculptures of feminine beauty; Combination of Vaishnava &

Shaiva themes

y All chambers featured Shikharas/Vimanas; Walls and stairs followed a zigzag pattern; I

y Incorporates Bhumiya Style – towering shikhara surrounded by rows of miniature, vertically stacked,

and tapering spires (kutas) (Turuvekere Muleshankara and Nuggehalli Sadashiva temple)

y Major Monuments: Chennakesava Temple (Belur) and Chennakesava Temple (Somanathapura) –

Lord Vishnu; Hoysaleswara Temple (Halebidu) – Lord Shiva; Doddabasappa Temple (Dambal);

Ladkhan Temple (Aihole); Vitthal Temple (Pandharpur) – core established by Vishnuvardhan

y UNESCO World Heritage List, 2023

Art and

Literature

y Kannada and Sanskrit literature flourished

y Hastimalla: Kannada poet and writer; wrote Purvapurana, Subhadra Harana, Vikrant-Kaurava,

Maithili-kalyana and Anjana-pavananjaya.

y Ornate Sculptures of Salabhanjika and Yakshas/Yakshinis

Vijayanagara Empire (1336–1646 CE)

The Vijayanagara Empire was the pre-eminent Hindu power in South India, established in 1336 CE as a bastion against

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 94

91

Foundation & Major Dynasties

Context Dismantled regional powers (Kakatiyas, Hoysalas, Kampili) amid Tughlaq invasions + Weakening Delhi

Sultanate + Simultaneous (1347 CE) emergence of rival Bahmani Sultanate north of the Krishna/Raichur

Doab

Foundation

(1336 CE)

Established by Harihara I and Bukka I – former feudatories of the Kakatiyas – Founded capital at

Vijayanagara ("City of Victory") on banks of Tungabhadra River (tributary of Krishna river) – present

day ruins of Hampi in Karnataka

Dynasties Sangama (1336–1485) – Saluva (1485–1505) – Tuluva (1505–1570) – Aravidu (1570–1646)

Sangama

Dynasty

y Harihara I (1336–1356) – Founder of empire; Established Nayankara system; Divided kingdom

into sthalas, simas, nadus; Built fort at Barkuru; Annexed Hoysala territories

– Division of empire among his brothers: Kampana (Nellur region); Muddappa (Managed

Mulabagalu); Marappa (Oversaw Chandragutti) – Bukka Raya (second-in-command)

y Bukka Raya I (1356–1377) – Defeated Madurai Sultanate; Extended empire to Rameswaram;

Capital shifted to Vijayanagara; Established diplomatic ties with China; Supported

scholars – Vidyananya, Sayana; Text: Madura Vijayam (by Gangadevi)

y Harihara II – Conquered Goa & Belgaum; Titles: Vadamarga Pravartaka; Sent an expedition to

northern Sri Lanka

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 95

92

Tuluva

Dynasty

y Vira Narasimha Raya (1505–1509 CE) – Founder

y Krishna Deva Raya (1509–1529 CE) –

– Zenith of Empire & contemporary of Babur – Defeated Bijapur, Golconda, and Orissa;

Conquered Raichur Doab

– Known as Abhinava Bhoja and Andhra Pitamah; Authored Amuktamalyada (Telugu) +

Sanskrit drama Jambavati Kalyanam + Ushaparinayam

– Patronised Ashtadiggajas – Allasani Peddana (works: Manucharitam and Harikathasaram);

Tenali Ramakrishna (works: Panduranga Mahatmyam, Udbhataardya Charitam and

Ghatikachalamahatmyam); Madayyagari Mallana; Nandi Thimmana; Dhurjati; Rambhadra;

Pingali Surana; Ramarajabhushanudu

– Also patronised Chatu Vittalanatha (work: Bhagavatha); Haridasa; Vyasatirtha

– Taxation: Tax rate on land fixed depending on the quality of the land; Private owners of

workshops paid an industries tax

– Founded Nagalapuram; gave permission to portuguese to build fort at Bhatkal

– Put a pillar of victory at Simhachalam (Visakhapatnam); Built Vijaya Mahal (House of

Victory), Hazara Rama Temple, and Vithal Swami Temple

y Achyuta Deva Raya (1529–1542 CE) – Patronized Purandaradasa (father of Carnatic music);

Portuguese traveller Fernao Nuniz visited

y Sada Siva Raya (1542–1570 CE) – Defacto power with Aliya Rama Raya; Deccan Sultanates –

confederacy against Vijayanagara; defeated at the Battle of Talaiakotta

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 96

93

Empire Under Vijayanagara

Administration y Central – monarchical, aided by a council of ministers;
confederacy rather than a highly centralized

state

y Territorial Hierarchy: Mandalam (Province) – Nadu (District) – Sthala
(Sub-district) – Grama

(Village).

y Amara Nayaka System: Military officers (Nayakas) were granted land
(Amaram) in lieu of salary

– maintained specific contingents for royal service + collected taxes +
managed commercial centres

(pettai) – hereditary Nayakships

y Key Officials: Mahapradhani (Prime Minister), Raysani (recorder of oral
orders), Karnikam

(accountant), Talara (watchman); Dalavay (commander); Adaippam (personal
attendant); Kariya-karta

(executive agents)

y Ayagar System: Local village governance body of 12 functionaries
(hereditary) – conducted village

affairs – paid via tax-free land or a share of village produce

y Criminal Justice – Harsh punishment

Economy y Remarkd as one of the wealthiest kingdoms of the world at that
time

y Agrarian Revenue – Land tax (Sist) fixed based on quality of land;
generally 1/6th – state-promoted

irrigation; Kadamal and Irai(land revenue tax), Vrai/Vetti(forced labour)

– Non-agrarian groups – Pattadaior (workshop people) + Kasayavargam (group
paying taxes in

cash)

y Villages – eight types for tax purposes: brahmadeya, devadana, madhepura,
sarvamanya, kodagi

lands, Rakta-kodangal lands, Guttagi lands and rest of the villages

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 97

94

Art, Architecture, and Literature

Art y Paintings: Murals at Veerabhadra temple at Lepakshi (Ramayana and Mahabharata); absence of blue color

y Sculpture: metal images of Krishna Deva Raya and his queens at Tirupati

Architecture y Architectural Style – Hybrid of Chola, Hoysala, Pandya, and Chalukya styles and Indo-Islamic elements

of Bijapur

y Key Features –

– Kalyana Mandapa (e.g., at the Vittala temple) + Raya Gopurams (decorated gateways) + Amman

Shrines (shrine dedicated to consort goddess of main deity) + Monolithic Sculptures (Stone Chariot

at Hampi) + Pillar motifs (Yali)

– Larger walls – highly decorated; Gopuramas on all side (earlier on front side); Concept of secular

buildings introduced (Lotus Mahal + Elephant Stables)

y Temples:

– Vittalaswami Temple (contains musical pillars; built by Devaraya II)

– Hazare Rama temple (built by Deva Raya I); Hazara Ramaswamy Temple (reliefs depicting

Ramayana; Krishna Deva Raya) at Hampi

– Major Vaishnavite and Shaivite pilgrimage centers: Varadharaja & Ekambaranatha Temples,

Kanchipuram

y Fortification of Hampi: Mentioned by Abdur Razzaq; No mortar or cementing agent used; arch and

dome on gateway

y Mahanavami Dibba: City's highest point; mentioned as the house of victory by Domingo Paes; Used for

royal ceremonies

Literature y Golden Age of Telugu Literature: Harikathasaram and Manucharitam (Allasani Peddanna);

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 98

95

Bahmani Empire (1347–1527 CE)

Bahmani Sultanate emerged from the Delhi Sultanate's decline in the 14th century, becoming the first independent

Islamic power in South India. Its two-century rule established a significant political and military rivalry with the

Vijayanagara Empire.

Bahmani Empire

y Founding and Context: Established in 1347 CE by Alauddin Hasan Bahman Shah (Hasan Gangu) – following a revolt

by Sada Amirs against the authority of Muhammad bin Tughlaq

y Extent and Capital: From the Wenganga River (north) to the Krishna River (south), to Daulatabad (west)

y Capital: Initially Gulbarga (Andhra Pradesh) – shifted to Bidar by Ahmad Shah Wali

Key Rulers y Muhammad Shah I (1358–1375): Defeated Kapaya Nayaks of Warangal and Bukka I

(Vijayanagara); Captured the fortress of Golkonda and the Turquoise Throne; Suppression of highway

robbery

y Taj-ud-din Firoz Shah (1397–1422) – most remarkable Bahmani ruler; Built an observatory near

Daulatabad + Yantaraja invented by Mahendra Suri; Secular Administration; Expanded towards

Berar; Defeated by Deva Raya I (1420)

y Ahmad Shah I (1422–1435) – Shifted capital to Bidar; Annexed Warangal; Known for his harsh

treatment of Hindus

y Muhammad Shah III (1463-1482) – kingdom reached its zenith; guidance of Prime Minister –

Mahmud Gawan (invited Persians for gunpowder technology)

y Mahmud Gawan (Malik-ul-Tujjar):

– Iranian merchant; Expansion – Annexed eastern territories + Defeated ruler of Orissa + Invaded

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 99

96

Features

Battle of

Talaikotta

1565 CE Confederacy (Bijapur + Ahmadnagar + Golconda + Bidar; Berar excluded) → decisive defeat of

Vijayanagara

Zones of

Conflicts

Raichur Doab (fertile land + diamond mines); Krishna-Godavari basin (trade ports); Marathwada/

Konkan region (sea ports)

Economy y Agriculture: Krishna→Tungabhadra + Krishna→Godavari doab → high produce; irrigation expansion →

tanks, canals, dams + rahat (Persian wheel); land revenue shift → kind to cash → urban growth

y Trade & Urbanisation: internal trade →luxury goods (sultans, nobility); urban centres → Daulatabad,

Gulbarga, Bidar; Golconda → global diamond centre

y Maritime Commerce: Port (Dabhol, Goa→Konkan, Masulipatnam) → → trade with Persia, Arabia,

China→ Arabian horses exchanged for →gold• (dinars); exports → fine textiles (muslin, silk→

Bengal, Gujarat), spices (pepper), saltpetre, indigo

y Industries: paper-making (China → Arabs) + treadle looms + crafts (metal-work, stone-carving, arms)

y Coinage: Bijapur huns + Sultanate tanka (silver) & jital (copper)

Dakkani

Language

y Precursor to Urdu → Evolved from Persian→Hindavi/Dahlavi→ Dravidian(Kannada,Telugu)→ Marathi

synthesis

Deccan

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 100

97

Architecture y Characteristics: Indo-Islamic synthesis; Monumental sizes
(large fort, grand mosques); Vaulting

techniques – Unsupported ceilings – massive freestanding domes;

y Features: Bulbous domes with narrow neck + 3-arched facade (Gol Gumbaz) +
Decoration – tile

mosaics, calligraphy (Rangin Mahal, Bidar) + Fortifications with Turkish and
Portuguese expertise

(Bidar & Golconda Forts) + Cornices (Charminar)

Gol Gumbaz (Muhammad

Adil Shah; Asia's largest

and world's second-largest

dome + Whispering

Gallery)

Charminar (Musi river, marks

end of a deadly plague)

Golconda Fort (granite walls, Fateh

Darwaza, Design with Echo effect)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 101

98

Mughals and Post Mughals

14

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. 'Yogavasistha' was translated into Persian by Nizamuddin Panipati during the reign of:

[2022]

- (a) Akbar
- (b) Humayun
- (c) Shahjahan
- (d) Aurangzeb

2. With reference to the cultural history of India, consider the following statements: [2018]

1. White marble was used in making Buland Darwaza and Khankah at Fatehpur Sikri.
2. Red sandstone and marble were used in making Bara Imambara and Rumi Darwaza at Lucknow.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

3. Which one of the following foreign travellers elaborately discussed diamonds and

diamond mines of India? [2018]

- (a) Francois Bernier
- (b) Jean-Baptiste Tavernier
- (c) Jean de Thevenot
- (d) Abbe Barthelemy Carre

4. Consider the following: [2015]

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 102

99

Mughal Rulers

Babur

(1526–1530 CE)

y Founder – Lineage: Descendant of Timur (paternal) and Chengiz Khan (maternal)

y Military Tactics: Tulguma/Rumi system (encirclement) + Ottoman gunners popularised gunpowder

and artillery – Victory over Ibrahim Lodi in the First Battle of Panipat in 1526 + defeated Rana Sanga

in Battle of Khanwa (1527) + Medini Rai in Battle of Chanderi (1528) + Mahmud Lodi and Afghan

chiefs in Battle of Ghagra (1529) – secured North West frontier from invasion and broke the Rajput

confederacy

y Architecture: Introduced Char-Bagh (symmetrical gardens with running water); built mosques

(Panipat, Rohilkhand).

y Literature: Authored Tuzuk-i-Babri (Babarnama) in Turkish (Later translated into Persian by Abdur

Rahim Khan-i-Khanan)

y Art: patronised Bihzad (Persian painter)

Humayun

(1530–1540 &

1555–1556 CE)

y Reign: Faced threats from Afghan and Rajput rulers – Siege of Chunar (1532) by Humayun – Lost

by Sher Shah Suri at Battle of Chausa (1539) and Battle of Kannauj/Bilgram (1540) – Exile in

Persia (1540-1555) at Shah Tahmasp's court – Reclamation of the Throne (1555; Battle of Sirhind)

– recaptured Delhi and Agra from Sikandar Shah Suri.

y Architecture: Foundation of Dinpanah city (Delhi); built Jamali Mosque and

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 103

100

Jahangir

(1605–1627 CE)

y Also known as Nur-ud-din Jahangir and Salim

y Reign: Ahmad Nagar declared independence under Malik Ambar (1608) + Subjugated Mewar by

Treaty with Amar Singh (1615) + ended long-standing Rajput-Mughal conflict; Lost Kandahar to

Safavids (1622); Suppressed Prince Khurram's rebellion and Mahabat Khan's coup (1626) + ordered

execution of 5th Sikh guru Arjan Dev

y Administration: Introduced *du-aspa*, *sih-aspa* (Modification of Mansabdari system); continued

Akbarr's *Sulh-i-Kul* religious policy

y Architecture: Shift to white marble (Moti Masjid in Lahore + Itmad-ud-daulah's Tomb in Agra),

Pietra Dura (floral inlay with semi-precious stones); Developed Shalimar and Nishat Bagh

(Kashmir).

y Art: Reached its zenith; shifted emphasis from illustrated manuscripts to album and individual portrait;

Muraqqas + individual paintings to be mounted in albums; patronised Ustad Mansur (animal specialist)

+ Bishan Das (portraits)

y Literature: Authored *Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri* in Persian + mentions the role of Banjaras in transportation

and aiding military logistics; *Iqbalnama-i-Jahangiri* by Mutamid Khan

y Foreigners: William Hawkins (1608) + Sir Thomas Roe (1615; obtained permission to establish a

British factory in Surat)

Shah Jahan

(1628–1658 CE)

y Reign: Expanded Mughal rule in Bijapur, Golconda, and northwest + Defeated

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 104

101

Later Mughals

(1707–1857

CE- period of

rapid

disintegration)

y Bahadur Shah I (1707-1712): Known as "Shah-i-Bekhabar"; Released Maratha prince Shahu;

Mewar and Marwar became independent

y Jahandar Shah (1712-1713): puppet ruler under Zulfiqar Khan; Abolished Jizya; Granted titles to

Jai Singh (Mirza Raja Sawai) and Ajit Singh (Maharaja); Introduced Ijarah (revenue farming)

y Farrukh Siyar (1713-1719): aided and murdered by Saiyyad Brothers; executed Banda Bahadur;

Royal Farman (Magna Carta) to East India Company; abolished Jizyah and the pilgrim tax

y Muhammad Shah/ Rangeela (1719-1748): Emergence of autonomous states: Hyderabad (Nizam-ul-

Mulk), Awadh (Saadat Khan), and Bengal (Murshid Quli Khan);

y Foreign Invasions:

• Nadir Shah's invasion (1739) • Battle of Karnal; surrender of Muhammad Shah

• Ahmad Shah Abdali's Invasions (1748-1767): Invaded multiple times • seized Delhi and

acknowledged Alamgir II as the Mughal emperor (Najib-ud-Daula as supreme regent) • Third

Battle of Panipat (1761)

y Alamgir II: Battle of Plassey(1757); repeated raids by Ahmad Shah Abdali

y Shah Alam II: Third Battle of Panipat (1761) • Maratha defeat by Abdali; Battle of Buxar (1764)

• Defeat of Shah Alam II, Mir Qasim and Shuja-ud-Daula

y Akbar II: First ruler under formal British protection; conferred title of

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 105

102

Mughal Empire Administration

y Central: Emperor (Badshah) aided by council of ministers (Diwan-i-Kul)

y Key Officials: Wazir/Diwan-i-Ala (Revenue); Mir Bakshi (military); Mir Saman (royal household and karkhanas);

Sadr-us-Sudur (religious endowments; Mustaufi (Auditor General); Mir-i-arz (in Charge of Petition)

y Units: Suba (Subedar) → Sarkar (Faujdar → law) and Amalguzar → revenue → Pargana (Shiqdar → Executive and

Quanungo → Land records) → Village (Muqaddam and Patwari); Mahattara and Pattakila (village headmen/elder)

y Mansabdari System:

→ Non-hereditary ranking system for civil and military officers → Zat (personal status and fixed salary) + Sawar

(number of cavalymen required to maintain)

→ Du-aspa and Sih-aspa → allowed increasing a noble's sawar rank without changing his zat rank;

→ Month-scale → adjusted salaries based on the actual realization (hasil) of the jagir's estimated income (jama)

y Jagirdari System: Integral to Mansabdari; Assignment of land revenue (Jagir) in lieu of cash salary → Tankha Jagir

(Transferable) + Watan Jagir (Hereditary and non-transferable; granted to Rajputs) + Mashrut Jagir (Conditional

assignments)

y Zamindari System: Hereditary rights over landed estates (landowners) → pay a fixed annual revenue to the Mughal court

after collecting taxes from peasants; acted as intermediaries → assisted state/Jagirdar in the collection of the remaining land

revenue; own armed forces → maintain law and order

y Zabti / Dahsala System (Todar Mal): Revenue fixed on the average yield of the land over the past 10 years → Land

Classification: Polaj (annually cultivated), Parati (fallow 1-2 years), Chachar (fallow 3-4 years), and Banjar (fallow 5+

years)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 106

103

Paintings y Foundation: Fusion of: Persian miniature tradition + Indigenous Indian styles + Later European

influence; Foundation laid by Humayun

y Features: Miniature paintings; emphasis on realism and naturalism; diverse subject matters; method of

foreshortening (objects depicted nearer and smaller than their actual size); use of rich material (fine paper,

gold, vibrant pigments)

y Painting Process: Tarh (Initial sketch) + Chiharanama (Portrait detailing) + Rangamizi (Colouring

stage) + Burnishing (final finish)

y Humayun paintings: Brought Persian artists from Safavid court (Abd al-Samad and Mir Sayyid Ali);

Commissioned + Khamsa of Nizami + Princes of the House of Timur

y Akbar paintings:

+ Established Tasvir Khana (royal atelier; Shift from folk to court art; use of three-dimensional figures

and the technique of foreshortening; integration of calligraphy

+ Notable Artists: Daswanth, Basawan, and Kesu

+ Famous Illustrated Manuscripts: Tutinama, Hamzanama, Anvar-i-Suhaili, and Gulistan of Sadi.

y Jehangir paintings:

+ Mughal paintings reached their peak + shifted from illustrated manuscripts to creating albums

(focus on infusing naturalism into portraiture)

+ Development of ornate margins surrounding paintings + Blending of European themes

+ Muraqqas: practice of mounting individual paintings into albums popular

+ Notable Paintings: Jahangir's Dream (By Abul Hasan); Painting of Jahangir in Darbar from the

Jahangirnama (by Abul Hasan and Manohar)

y Shah Jahan paintings: More stylised & idealised; Luxurious & decorative

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 107

104

y Administration:

• Nature of Rule – Highly centralised; Efficient bureaucracy accountable to ruler; Foundation for Mughal

administrative structure

• Central Administration (under Four main ministers): Diwan-i-Wizarat – Revenue & Finance; Diwan-i-Ariz –

Army; Diwan-i-Rasalat – Foreign Affairs; Diwan-i-Insha – Communications

• Provincial Administration: Empire divided into 47 Sarkars (Chief Shiqdar: Law & order; Chief Munsif: Judicial

authority) – Paraganas (Shiqdar: Military; Amin: Revenue; Fotedar: Treasurer; Karkuns – Accountants) – Iqtas

y Land system: Introduced Patta (title deed) and Qabuliyat (agreement) + land measurement via Sikandari gaz + Zabti-i-

har-sal (annual land assessment); cultivable lands under three heads (good, middle, bad); Religiously tolerant

y Currency: Introduced silver Rupayia and copper Dam; Tri-metallic system: Gold Silver Copper

y Architecture: Built Purana Qila (Delhi), Rohtas Fort (Pakistan), and his octagonal Mausoleum at Sasaram.

y Infrastructure: Constructed 4 major highways; Built sarais (rest houses) with wells; Improved postal system; Rebuilt and

expanded Grand Trunk Road

y Literature: Patronized Malik Muhammad Jayasi (Padmavat)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 108

105

Marathas

The Maratha Empire was a pivotal force in 18th-century India, marking the decline of Mughal hegemony and the rise of indigenous

regional sovereignty. The Maratha Empire was established by Chhatrapati Shivaji in the late 17th century as a response to the chaos

and misrule in the Deccan region. The confederacy was officially recognized as a tributary state by Emperor Bahadur Shah I in 1707

after a long rebellion. While Shivaji established the foundations, the subsequent Peshwa era transformed the state into a pan-Indian

confederacy until the British intervention.

Maratha Empire

Historical

context

Early 17th century Deccan – decline of Ahmadnagar Sultanate + sustained contest between Bijapur and the

Mughals – rise of local military elites (deshmukhs) – political fragmentation creates space for regional state

formation

Factors for Rise:

Geographical Advantage – Western Ghats, forests & hill forts, Ideal for guerrilla warfare (Ganimi

Kava); Network of forts: Torna, Raigad, Sinhagad

Religious – Social Unity – Influence of Bhakti movement Saints (Tukaram, Ramdas, Eknath); Sense of

regional identity

Political Experience – Marathas served in Bijapur & Ahmadnagar administrations – Shahji Bhonsle

laid early foundations – Shivaji consolidated power

Geographical Extent: Initially centered in Maharashtra – later expanded to parts of Karnataka, Madhya

Pradesh, and others

Capitals: Raigad Fort, Gingee, Satara, and Pune

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 109

106

Maratha Administration, Economy, Society

Central

Government

y Chhatrapati as supreme authority; assisted by a council of eight ministers

â™| Mukhya Pradhan (Peshwa): General administration and finance; later became the de facto head

â™| Sar-i-Naubat (Senapati): Honorary post for the military commander

â™| Amatya/Majumdar: Finance

â™| Waqenavis: Intelligence, police, post, and household affairs.

â™| Surnavis (Sachiv/Chitnis): General Secretary; handled official correspondence.

â™| Sumant (Dabir): Master of ceremonies and Foreign Affairs.

â™| Nyayadish: Administration of Justice.

â™| Pandit Rao: Charities and ecclesiastical affairs

Provincial

administration

y Hierarchy of prant â†' sarkar (Tarf) â†' pargana â†' village (mauza) â†' retention of local officials

under state supervision â†' ensures revenue extraction + military mobilisation

y Maratha Confederacy (The Big Five): Peshwas (Poona); Gaikwads (Baroda); Bhonsles (Nagpur);

Holkars (Indore); Scindias (Gwalior)

Military

administration

y Cavalry (Paga): Consisted of Bargirs (equipped and paid by the state) and Silahdars (maintained by nobles).

y Infantry: Included highly mobile Mavli foot soldiers; during crises, peasants served as part-time soldiers.

y Forts: The backbone of defense; each fort was co-managed by three officers

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 110

107

Temple Architecture

16

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to the cultural history of India, the term “Panchayatana”™ refers to: [2014]

- (a) an assembly of village elders
- (b) a religious sect
- (c) a style of temple construction
- (d) an administrative functionary

Indian architecture is a vast synthesis of diverse indigenous traditions and foreign influences, evolving from the planned cities of the

Indus Valley to the refined Indo-Islamic monuments of the medieval period. Within this continuum, temple architecture developed

distinct regional styles shaped by dynasties, geography, and religious traditions.

• Temple architecture, with the development of a square sanctum and a pillared portico emerged during the Gupta period.

• There was a gradual progression from the flat-roofed, monolithic temples in the initial stages to the sculptured “shikhara”™ in the later years.

• Indian temple architecture evolved into Nagara (North), Dravida (South), and Vesara styles, featuring shikhara or vimana,

garbhagriha, mandapa, intricate sculptures, and symbolic cosmological layouts reflecting regional and religious traditions.

Nagara and Dravida Schools of Architecture

Dimension Nagara Style

(Northern India)

Dravida Style

(Peninsular/Southern India)

Chronology &

Evolution

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 111

108

Nagara Sub-Schools (North India)

Sub-School Key Architecture Distinctive Dimensions & Material

Odisha

(Konark)

Rekha deul

(curvilinear shikhara),

Jagamohan

(mandapa).

y Exterior walls are lavishly carved while interiors are plain; iron girders were used instead of pillars to support roofs. Square Ground plan and temples

are uniquely enclosed by boundary walls.

Eg: Konark Sun Temple; Lingaraja Temple, Bhubaneswar

Chandela

(Khajuraho)

Panchayatan style,

Antarala

(vestibular entrance).

y Both interior and exterior walls are lavishly decorated; sculptures often feature erotic themes. Built on high platforms with subsidiary shrines creating a "mountain range" effect.

Eg: Lakshmana Temple (Khajuraho)

Solanki

(Modhera)

Suryakund

(step-tank), Torans

(arched gateways).

y Walls are generally devoid of carvings; the garbhagriha connects to the mandapa both internally and externally. Equinox sun rays fall directly on

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 112

109

Religion and Philosophical

Schools 17

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Which one of the following pairs does not form part of the six systems of Indian

Philosophy? [2014]

(a) Mimamsa and Vedanta

(b) Nyaya and Vaisheshika

(c) Lokayata and Kapalika

(d) Sankhya and Yoga

2. With reference to the history of philosophical thought in India, consider the following

statements regarding Sankhya school: [2013]

1. Sankhya does not accept the theory of rebirth or transmigration of soul.

2. Sankhya holds that it is the self-knowledge that leads to liberation and not any

exterior influence or agent.

Which of the statements given above is/ are correct?

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 only

(c) Both 1 and 2

(d) Neither 1 nor 2

Indian philosophy developed as an inquiry into the mysteries of life, death, and the forces governing the universe. Major schools

identified four primary goals of life: Artha (wealth), Dharma (moral order), Kama (pleasure), and Moksha (salvation). These

schools are broadly classified into two categories based on their acceptance of the Vedas:

• Orthodox Schools (Astika): These schools, collectively known as Shat Darshana, recognize the authority of the Vedas as

supreme revealed scriptures.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History -- Part 113

110

Theory of

Reality

Dualism (Dvaita):

Purusha (soul) and

Prakriti (matter) --

believes in rebirth/

transmigration of soul

Prakriti

(matter) and

Purusha

(consciousness

/ self).

Reality

verified

through logic

Universe --

five elements

(Dravya);

atomic

theory

Vedas as

eternal truth

Brahm is real;

world is Maya;

Atma = Brahm

Methods Pratyaksha

(Perception),

Anumana (Inference),

Shabda (Hearing)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 114

111

Ajivikas

(Fatalism)

y Founder: Makkhali Gosala (~5th c. BCE; former companion of Mahavira)

y Core doctrine: Niyati (absolute determinism) – everything pre-ordained

y Beliefs: Rejects Karma (human effort futile) + material soul in all beings
+ naked, austere asceticism

y Patronage: Popular in Magadha; Bindusara a follower

y Centres: Sravasti as headquarters; Barabar Caves donated by Ashoka & Dasharatha

Ajnanas

(Radical

Skepticism)

y Core belief: Radical skepticism – knowledge of nature impossible; even if possible, useless for

salvation

y Salvation: End of pain

y Philosophy: – Ignorance is Best/Bliss –

Other Schools

Beyond the Orthodox and Heterodox schools, Āśaiva ascetic and Tantric traditions represent radical devotional and yogic

paths worshipping Shiva as supreme reality. These fringe movements emphasized siddhis, transgression, and non-dual realization,

influencing Bhakti.

Pasupata 2nd CE; Earliest systematic Shaivism; features Pashupata Sutra (bathing three times daily in ash, acting

insane, etc.), 5-stage initiation (ritual purity – ascetic tapa – supernatural powers (siddhis)); temple-based;

prevalent in Kashmir/Gujarat

Kapalika 6th – 10th CE; Kapala-bearing extremists – skull rituals, cremation ground practices; extreme asceticism

taboo-breaking.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 115

112

3. Consider the following pairs: [2016]

Famous Place Region

1. Bodhgaya : Baghelkhand
2. Khajuraho : Bundelkhand
3. Shirdi : Vidarbha
4. Nasik (Nashik) : Malwa
5. Tirupati : Rayalaseema

Which of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

- (a) 1, 2 and 4
- (b) 2, 3, 4 and 5
- (c) 2 and 5 only
- (d) 1, 3, 4 and 5

4. Consider the following pairs: [2015]

Place of Pilgrimage : Location

1. Srisailem : Nallamala Hills
2. Omkareshwar : Satmala Hills
3. Pushkar : Mahadeo Hills

Which of the above pairs is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Brahma Temples

Pushkar,

Rajasthan

Oldest Brahma temple (sacred Lake Pushkar); November fair (camel mela);
built 14th CE;

located on Aravali Hills

Vishnu Temples

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 116

113

Omkareshwar, Narmada Island (Madhya Pradesh) On an Island shaped like "Om";
Mandhata Hills

Mallikarjuna, Srisailem (Andhra Pradesh) On Krishna river, Nallamalla Hills;
also a Shakti Peetha; Patronized

by Satavahanas, Rashtrakutas and Vijayanagara rulers

Kedarnath (Uttarakhand) Highest Jyotirlinga; Himalayan shrine

Bhimashankar (Maharashtra) Source region of Bhima river

Kashi Vishwanath, Varanasi (Uttar Pradesh) On the banks of the Ganges,
believed to grant salvation

Trimbakeshwar, Nashik (Maharashtra) Origin of Godavari river

Vaidyanath, Deogarh (Jharkhand) Associated with healing

Nageshwar, Dwarka region (Gujarat) Underground lingam; associated with Shiva
Purana

Ramanathaswamy, Rameswaram (Tamil Nadu) Closely linked to Ramayana

Grishneshwar, Ellora (Maharashtra) Near Ellora Caves

Major Shakti Peethas

Vaishno Devi, Trikuta Hills (J&K) Goddess Vaishnavi meditated and attained
spiritual enlightenment.

Kamakhya, Guwahati (Assam) Associated with the menstruation (fertility)
+ annual Ambubachi Mela

Kalighat, Kolkata (West Bengal) Major center of Tantric worship; fierce yet
benevolent form; associated with

19th-century Kalighat paintings

Meenakshi, Madurai (Tamil Nadu) Intricately decorated 14 Gopurams; form of
Parvati + love, fertility, and the

warrior spirit; built by Nayak Dynasty

Jwalamukhi, Kangra (Himachal Pradesh) Eternal flame shrine

Major Sun Temples

Konark Sun Temple (Puri, Odisha) Chariot-shaped; UNESCO World Heritage

Modhera Sun Temple (Gujarat) Solanki architecture

Martand Sun Temple (Jammu & Kashmir) Built by Lalitaditya; now in ruins

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 117

114

Art and Culture

18

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to the famous Sattriya dance, consider the following statements: [2014]

1. Sattriya is a combination of music, dance and drama.
2. It is a centuries-old living tradition of Vaishnavites of Assam.
3. It is based on classical Ragas and Talas of devotional songs composed by Tulsidas, Kabir and Mirabai.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3 only

2. Consider the following pairs: [2014]

1. Garba : Gujarat
2. Mohiniattam : Odisha
3. Yakshagana : Karnataka

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3 only

3. In the context of cultural history of India, a pose in dance and dramatics called

‘Tribhanga’ has been a favourite of Indian artists from ancient times till today. Which

one of the following statements best describes this pose? [2013]

- (a) One leg is bent and the body is slightly but oppositely curved at waist and neck

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 118

115

Eight Classical Dance Forms

Bharatnatyam

(Tamil Nadu)

y History: Oldest form – origin in Sadir/Dashiattam; Based on Natyashastra & Abhinaya Darpana

Codified in 19th century by Tanjore Quartet (Chinnaiah, Ponniah, Vadivelu and Shivanandam)

Revival by E. Krishna Iyer + Rukmini Devi Arundale in 20th century

y Derived meaning: Bha – Bhava (expression) + Ra – Raga (melody) + Ta – Tala (rhythm) Natyam

theatrical dance

y Features: Fire Dance – symbolises manifestation of fire – Ekcharya lasyam (one dancer, multiple

roles); Equal emphasis on Tandava and Lasya; knees mostly bent – weight equally distributed across

both the feet

y Elements: Alarippu (invocation) – Jatiswaram (Nritta) – Shabdam (short song) + Varnam (Nritya

core) – Padam (abhinaya) – Thillana (pure dance finale).

y Key elements: Tanjore Quartet (systematized it) + Katakamukha Hasta (Om symbol) + knees

bent – weight distributed

y Accompanied by Carnatic music, mridangam & cymbals

Kuchipudi

(Andhra

Pradesh)

y History: Named after Kuchelapuram village – Originally performed by group of actors known as

Kusselavas – Patronage of the Vijayanagar and Golconda rulers

y Formalised by Siddhendra Yogi (17th C; authored – Bhamana Kalapam) – Revival by Balasaraswati +

Ragini Devi in 20th century

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 119

116

Odissi (Odisha) y History: Earliest examples in Udayagiri-Khandagiri caves â†’ derives its name from the â€œOdra nrityaâ€™

mentioned in Natya Shastra â†’ Practised by Maharis (temple) and Gotipuas (boys) â†’ patronised by

the Jain King Kharavela â†’ Revival by Charles Fabri + Indrani Rahman.

y Features:

â™¦ Similar to Bharatnatyam in the use of Mudras and postures

â™¦ Water element: Static lower body + hand gestures + torso movement.

â™¦ Mobile sculpture: Dancers create intricate geometrical shapes and patterns with her body.

â™¦ Dancers use elaborate hair-style, silver jewellery, long necklace, etc.

â™¦ Postures: Tribhanga (three-bends) + Chowk (masculine/square stance).

â™¦ Elements: Mangalacharan (beginning) â†’ Batu nritya â†’ Pallavi â†’ Moksha (liberation finale)

y Hindustani classical music performed; Musical instrumentsâ†’ Manjira, Pakhawaj, Sitar, Flute,

Manipuri

(Manipur)

y History: Mythological origin (Celestial dance of Shiva and Parvati in valleys of Manipur) â†’ Origin

traced to festival of Lai Haraoba â†’ Gained prominence via Vaishnavism â†’ Revival by Raja Bhag

Chandra + Rabindranath Tagore.

y Features:

â™¦ Performed generally by females; Focus on devotion, not sensuality

â™¦ Incorporates both Tandava and Lasya, emphasis on latter

â™¦ Faces covered by veil; gentle hand and knee movements;

â™¦ Naga Bandha mudra: Body is connected in shape of â€œ8â€™

â™¦ Theme: Ras Leela, compositions of Jayadeva and Chandidas

y Musical Instruments: Drum (pung), flute, khartals, dhols ,etc.

y Thang-Ta and Sankirtana are also influenced by Manipuri dance.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 120

117

Jawara

(Madhya Pradesh)

Bundelkhand region; involves balancing a basket full of jawar on the head while

dancing to heavy instrumental music.

Matki

(Madhya Pradesh)

Solo dance by women of the Malwa region for weddings and festivals; involves balancing multiple earthen pots on the head.

Gaur Muria (Chhattisgarh) By Muria tribes in Bastar; imitate the movements of a bison in a group.

Jat-Jatin (Bihar) Popular in Mithila; represents the tender love and quarrels of a married couple.

Bihu

(Assam)

Group dance featuring rapid hand movements and brisk footsteps to celebrate harvest

and joy.

Singhi Chham

(Sikkim)

Mask dance – performers dress in furry lion costumes symbolising the snow lion to

pay tribute to Kanchenjunga.

Kummi

(Tamil Nadu, Kerala)

Performed by women in a circular formation; unique for the absence of music, as

rhythm is generated by clapping.

Mayilattam (Kerala, Tamil

Nadu)

Known as the Peacock dance; young girls dress as peacocks with colourful

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 121

118

Dumhal (J&K) Performed by Wattal tribe in colourful costumes with a tall conical hat for men

Hojagiri (Tripura) Movement of only the lower-half of the body; performed during Lakshmi puja

Garadi (Puducherry) Performed to celebrate the victory of Lord Rama over Ravana

Tippani

(Gujarat)

Saurashtra region of Gujarat; performed exclusively by women – beat floors with

tippani

Indian Music

Music in Indian culture dates back to the Vedic era, with Narada Muni introducing music to Earth and the concept of Nada

Brahma (the sound pervading the universe). Ancient instruments like the seven-holed flute from the Indus Valley Civilization

and the Ravanahatha from Sri Lanka – the Harappan Civilization highlight India's rich musical history.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to Mian Tansen, which one of the following statements is not correct?

[2019]

- (a) Tansen was the title given to him by Emperor Akbar.
- (b) Tansen composed Dhrupads on Hindu gods and goddesses.
- (c) Tansen composed songs on his patrons.
- (d) Tansen invented many Ragas.

Literary Sources of Indian Music

y Sama Veda (c. 1500 BC): Earliest source – set Rig Vedic hymns to musical notes : basis of Indian music; Gandharva

Veda (Upaveda of Sama Veda) – dedicated to the science of music.

y Natya Shastra (Bharata Muni; c. 200 BC – 200 AD): Also known as Fifth Veda – epitome of Nāṭya-yaveda; first text available

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 122

119

Carnatic Classical Music

Practiced in Southern India, this indigenous system, rooted in Bharata's Natya Shastra, follows a rigid structure primarily

based on the sahitya, or the lyrical and literary quality of its highly evolved Kṛiti compositions. It prioritizes vocal mastery as

the primary medium of artistic expression.

y Structure: Kṛiti-based – Pallavi (theme) + Anu Pallavi + Charana (conclusion).

y Pitamaha: Purandara Dasa (founding father); The Trinity – Tyagaraja (Ram devotee, Pancharatna Kṛitis) + Muthuswami

Dikshitar + Syama Sastri.

y Theoretical Framework: Raga based on 72 Melakartas (parent scales); Tala has rigid structure + 3 components (Laghu,

Dhṛutam, Anu-dhṛutam)

Hindustani vs Carnatic Music

Dimension Hindustani Music (North India) Carnatic Music (South India)

Nature of

Style

Syncretic & Assimilative – Result of the blending of Hindu and Iranian/Persian systems.

Indigenous & Purist – Retained older Indian traditions with minimal external influence.

Primary

Influence

Heavy Persian/Arabic influence via Delhi

Sultanate and Mughals.

Deeply rooted in Bhakti traditions and Tamil

devotionalism (Azhwars/Nayanmars).

Core

Philosophy

Focus on the Gharana system (lineage-based

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 123

120

Language

Base

Primarily Braj Bhasha, Persian, Urdu, and

Hindi.

Primarily Telugu, Kannada, Tamil, and Sanskrit.

Scale &

Notes

Uses 12 swaras; flexible, allowing room for

improvisation within the raga framework.

Uses 12 swaras; highly structured, emphasizing

mathematical precision in tala.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. A community of people called Manganiyars is well-known for their: [2014]

(a) Martial arts in North-East India

(b) Musical tradition in North-West India

(c) Classical vocal music in South India

(d) Pietra dura tradition in Central India

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. The first gandharva mahavidyalaya, a music training school, was set up in 1901 by

vishnu digambar paluskar in [2025]

(a) Delhi

(b) Gwalior

(c) Ujjain

(d) Lahore

Folk Music

Manganiyars

(Rajasthan/Gujarat)

Merasi Muslim bards sing Alexander, kings, battles; use Kamaicha instrument praising Muslim

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 124

121

Modern Developments

Gandharva

Mahavidyalaya

Vishnu Digambar Paluskar: 1st (Lahore, 1901); Pune (1932, Vinayakrao Patwardhan); Delhi (1939, Vinay

Chandra Maudgalya). Hindustani revival via graded exams (Akhil Bharatiya Mandal)

Prayag Sangeet

Samiti

Prayagraj (1926): Ranjit Singh + others. Hindustani music diplomas; Sangeet Kala Kendra; annual

conferences

Bhatkhande

Institutions

Vishnu Narayan Bhatkhande: Lucknow (1926) + Mumbai. Hindustani notation (Bhatkhande Thaata); raga

classification; degrees (Visharad).

Kalakshetra

Foundation

Rukmini Devi Arundale: Chennai (1936). Carnatic music + Bharatanatyam; integrates dance-music;

UNESCO-recognized.

Sangeet Natak

Akademi

New Delhi (1952): National performing arts academy (music, dance, drama). Awards (Padma-like),

fellowships, regional centres (Kathak Kendra).

Paintings

Painting as an art form has flourished in India since prehistoric times.

Indian paintings are primarily classified as murals and

miniatures. Murals are large works executed on walls and ceilings whereas;

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 125

122

Shadanga of Paintings

y Rupa-Bheda – Knowledge of forms; ability to distinguish and depict subjects accurately.

y Pramana – Correct proportion, measurement, anatomy.

y Bhava – Expression of emotion; gives life and movement.

y Lavanya-Yojanam – Grace and aesthetic beauty in composition.

y Sadrishyam – Resemblance to subject or intended vision.

y Varnika-Bhanga – Proper use and harmony of colours.

Prehistoric Paintings

Petroglyphs – Rock engravings using mineral pigments

y Upper Palaeolithic: Large animal figures (bison, elephant) depicted; Linear style; green & dark red colours; Stick-like

human forms ; Major sites – Bhimbetka (Madhya Pradesh), Lakhudiyar (Uttarakhand)

y Mesolithic: Smaller figures – hunting scenes dominate; Naturalistic animals; stylised humans; Community dances

common; More use of red colour

y Chalcolithic: Similar motifs in pottery & rock art (cross-hatched patterns); Use of multiple colours (white, ochre, red,

green, black); Depiction of battle and preparedness; Geometrical shapes; Evidence of art of tanning skins; Major sites –

Narsingharh (MP), Jogimara Caves and Kohabaur rock art (CG), Gudahandi Rock Shelter and Yogimatha Rock Shelter

(Odisha)

Mural Paintings

Executed on walls or solid structures, predominantly between 10th BC-10th AD; Fresco – technique of mural painting

executed upon freshly laid lime plaster. Major paintings include:

y Ajanta (MH): Patrons – Maurya, Gupta and Shunga; not true frescoes – painted after the plaster had set; related to

Buddhism; Famous paintings – Padmapani, Vajrapani, Manjusri, Mahajanaka, Umaga Jataka, Dying Princess

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 126

123

Miniature Paintings

Miniatures are finely detailed small-scale paintings, usually not larger than about 25 square inches, with figures depicted at roughly one-sixth of their actual size.

Early

(Before Delhi Sultanate)

y Pala School (8th–12th C): Related to Buddhism; Executed on palm leaf or vellum paper;

Characterized by lonely single figures and subdued tones; Astasahasrika Prajnaparamita

(Perfection of Wisdom); Prominent painters: Dhimman and Vitapala.

y Apabhramsa School (11th–15th C): Origin in Gujarat and Mewar; focused on Jain and

Vaishnava (Gita Govinda) themes; Patronized by Chalukya Dynasty; Style includes fish-

shaped bulging eyes, pointed noses, and stiff figures; Famous – Kalpasutra and Kalakacharya-

Katha

Delhi Sultanate Synthesis of Persian and indigenous styles began – preference to illustrated manuscripts

y Flat color application, black demarcated outlines, and human figures shown in a three-quarter

angle with a detached appearance.

y Lodi Khuladar style – large eyes, pointed noses, checkerboard-patterned garments.

y Example: Laur-Chanda (Chandayana) paintings under Firuz Shah Tughluq

Malwa Sultanate Early Indo-Persian influence – Mandu school under Ghurids/Khiljis/others – evolved later into

the Malwa School of Rajasthan under Rajputs

y Key Patron: Sultan Ghiyath Shah (1469–1500) and his son Nasir Shah (1500–1510).

y Bold colors, Persianate figures (turbaned, elongated) + Indian facial features, flat perspective,

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 127

124

Pahari School of

Painting

(17th–19th Century)

Developed in sub-Himalayan states (Jammu to Almora) following the dispersal of Mughal-trained

artists. Canvases are full of movement – each figure distinct in composition and pigmentation;

Key Artists – Nainsukh, Manaku, and Sansar Chand. Major Sub-Groups include:

y Basohli (J&K): The early phase; featured expressive faces, receding hairlines, and lotus-petal

eyes; Intense use of primary colors; patronage by Raja Kirpal Pal; famous artist Devi Das

(Rasamanjari)

y Guler (HP): Transition phase between Basohli and Kangra; Introduced refined Mughal-style

naturalism – soft, refined and natural look; Portraits of Raja Balwant Singh of Jasrota

y Kangra (HP): Evolved from Guler; reached its pinnacle under Raja Sansar Chand (mid-18th

C). Known for sensuality and intelligence; focused on Gita Govinda, Nal Damayanti, and the

'Twelve Months' (depicting emotions across seasons)

y Kullu-Mandi (HP): Retained a folk/primitive character; simpler and less influenced by

Mughal courtly refinement; use of dark and dull colours

y Chamba(HP): Focused on the Ragamala series; unique facial profiles and use of blue/red

borders.

Ragamala Paintings Illustrative series based on the 'Garland of Ragas' – Personifies each Raga through a color

describing a Nayaka (hero) or Nayika (heroine) in a specific mood; identifies the season, time of

day, and associated Hindu deity; Found across Pahari, Rajasthani, Deccan,

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 128

125

East India (Bihar, Jharkhand, Odisha, West Bengal)

Madhubani / Mithila (Bihar):

Traditionally done by village women;

Hindu motifs (Krishna, Rama, Durga,

Shiva) and symbolic figures like fish

(luck/fertility); Rice paste and

vegetable colors on walls (mud/cow

dung base); currently executed on

paper and cloth; Double-line

borders, bold colors, ornate patterns,

and exaggerated facial features; GI

Status

Pattachitra (Odisha): Patta

(cloth) and Chitra (picture);

Colors from natural sources

(burnt coconut shells, lamp

black); brush-only outlines (no

pencil/ charcoal); Themes:

Jagannath, Vaishnava, Shakti,

and Shaiva cults: GI Status.

Paitkar (Jharkhand): Ancient tribal scroll

paintings linked to the goddess Ma Mansa;

Focused on the human journey post-death :

currently on the verge of extinction

Tikuli Art (Bihar): Derived from the

local word for "Bindi"; Hardboard is

cut into shapes and coated with 4–5

layers of enamel for a polished finish;

features Madhubani motifs

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 129

126

West and Central India (Gujarat, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, MP)

Warli (Gujarat/Maharashtra):

Tribal art dating back to 2500 BC;

Uses basic geometric vocabulary

(triangle, circle, square) : humans/

animals represented by two joined

triangles; White pigment (gum and

rice powder) on a mud/cow dung

base; central motif is the Chauk

(square) featuring Palaghata (fertility

goddess)

Phad (Rajasthan): Religious

scroll art on long cloth (15â€30

ft); Deeds of local deities

Pabuji and Devnarayan :

features large eyes, round faces,

and joyful processions.

Pithora (Gujarat/MP): Ritualistic tribal wall

paintings to bring peace and prosperity;

Depiction of animals, particularly horses, is a

dominant feature

South and Himalayan India

Kalamkari (Andhra Pradesh):

Kalam (bamboo pen);

Centresâ†Srikalahasti (free-hand,

mythological) and Machilipatnam

(block-printing style); Cotton fabric

and vegetable dyes: GI Status

Cheriyal Scroll (Telangana):

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 130

127

Indian Martial Arts

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to India's culture and tradition, what is Kalaripayattu?
[2014]

(a) It is an ancient Bhakti cult of Shaivism still prevalent in some parts of South India.

(b) It is an ancient style bronze and brass work still found in southern part of Coromandel

area.

(c) It is an ancient form of dance-drama and a living tradition in the northern part of

Malabar.

(d) It is an ancient martial art and a living tradition in some parts of South India.

Answer: 1. (d)

Kalaripayattu (KL) Origin c. 3rd century BC; focuses on footwork, kicks, and strikes

Silambam

(TN)

Promoted by Chola/Chera/Pandya kings; mentioned in Silappadikaram; Kuttu Varisai

Empty-Hand Silambam

Kuttu Varisai (TN) Unarmed component of Silambam; focuses on athleticism via yoga and gymnastics.

Thang-ta

(Manipur)

Armed with "Thang"-sword, "Ta"-spear; used historically against the British. Part of Huyen

Langlon (Sara an unarmed art)

Gatka (Punjab) Weapon-based art of the Sikhs; features Kirpan, Talwar, and Kataar.

Pari-khanda (Bihar) Created by Rajputs; steps and techniques form the

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 131

128

Indian Festivals

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following pairs: [2018]

Tradition State

1. Chapchar Kut festival – Mizoram
2. Khongjom Parba ballad – Manipur
3. Thang-Ta dance – Sikkim

Which of the pairs given above is/are correct ?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 2 and 3

2. Consider the following pairs: [2017]

Traditions Communities

1. Chaliha Sahib Festival – Sindhis
2. Nanda Raj Jaat Yatra – Gonds
3. Wari-Warkari – Santhals

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) None of the above

Festival Description

Chapchar Kut Mizoram; celebrated after the completion of the arduous Jhum (clearing of forest) task.

Chaliha Sahib Observed by the Sindhi community to offer thanks to Jhulelal.

Khongjom Parba

(Manipur)

Ballad narrating 1891 Battle of Khongjom (Manipuri resistance vs British); honors martyrs like

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 132

129

Losar Tibetan New Year; in Arunachal Pradesh (Monpa tribe), Ladakh, and Sikkim.

Wangala Also known as the "100 Drums Festival"; post-harvest festival of Garo tribe in Meghalaya.

Attukal Pongala Kerala; known for the largest annual gathering of women

Nabanna A Bengali harvest festival – marking the arrival of the new crop.

Moatsu Mong Ao Naga tribe in Nagaland; celebrated after the sowing is done to invoke God's blessings.

Thrissur Pooram Kerala (Vadakkunnathan Temple); famous for its grand elephant procession and fireworks

Maghi Celebrated in Muktsar in the memory of forty Sikh martyrs (Chalis Mukte)

Sodal Mela Punjab; organised to pay homage to baba Sodal

Hola Mohalla Sikh festival; held in Anandpur Sahib; started by Guru Govind Singh for mock battles and military

exercises

Ulambara Buddhist festival; to relieve the sufferings of ghosts

Hemis Gompa At Hemis Gompa Monastery in Ladakh to celebrate the birth anniversary of Guru Rinpoche

(Padmasambhava).

Saga Dawa (Triple

Blessed Festival)

By Buddhist communities in Sikkim; to commemorate the birth, enlightenment and death

(parinirvana) of Buddha

Losoong Festival Sikkimese New year; by Bhutia and Lepcha tribes; celebration of the harvest season

Songkran Buddhist festival; observed like a spring cleaning, symbolizing renewal.

Paryushana Jain festival; focuses on self-discipline, non-violence (Ahimsa), repentance, and asking for

forgiveness (Micchami Dukkadam)

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 133

130

Indian Handicrafts

Puthukkuli

shawls

Toda tribe embroidery (Nilgiris, TN); geometric red-black motifs on white cotton shawls

(Pugur/"flower").

Sujni embroidery Bihar; narrative quilting/chain-stitch; depicts rural life, flora-fauna on cloth.

Uppada Jamdani saris Andhra Pradesh (East Godavari); lightweight silk-cotton weave; fine Jamdani motifs.

Banaras Sarees Uttar Pradesh; zari gold-silver brocade; Mughal-era pitloom sarees.

Chanderi sarees Madhya Pradesh; sheer silk-cotton; gold zari borders; Scindia patronage.

Kancheepuram sarees Tamil Nadu; temple silk; gold zari, korvai edging; contrasting borders/body.

Bhadrachalam fabrics Telangana; Pochampally Ikat; tie-dye resist silk-cotton; geometric motifs.

Madhubani painting Bihar; Mithila folk art; natural pigments on walls/cloth; mythic-floral motifs.

Kashmiri Pashmina J&K; fine cashmere shawls; pashmina wool from Changthangi goats; twill tapestry weave.

Phulkari Punjab; floral embroidery; silk floss on khaddar dupatta; Bagh/Satti styles.

Kanchipuram silk Tamil Nadu; heavyweight brocade sarees; mulberry silk-zari; temple weddings.

Recent GI Tagged Products

Pashmina Shawls (J&K) Textile Woven from the fine undercoat of the Changthangi goat

Traditional Lepcha Musical

Instruments, Sikkim

Handicraft 10+ folk instruments (e.g., Tung-Tsing cymbal, Phembung bamboo flute) of Lepcha tribe; bamboo/metal; ritual/dance use.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 134

131

Thooyamalli Rice, Tiruvarur

(TN)

Agricultural Aromatic short-grain paddy; rain-fed, medicinal (Ayurveda); soft

texture, faint fragrance.

Ambasamudram Choppu

Saman, Tirunelveli (TN)

Handicraft Betel leaves & areca plates (eco plates); podukku leaf folding; podu

cultivation in Ambasamudram.

Ambaji White Marble,

Ambaji (Gujarat)

Natural

Mineral

Translucent white marble; fine grain, low porosity; quarried for temple sculptures/statues.

Meerut Bugle (UP) Handicraft Brass military bugle; hand-hammered, engraved; used in parades/army;

200+ yr brass legacy.

Meerut Gajak (UP) Foodstuff Sesame-jaggery brittle sweet; winter delicacy, til-gur crunch; Mughal-

era recipe.

Meerut Rewri (UP) Foodstuff Til-patti variant; sesame-liquefied jaggery discs; festive, til gur

proportions unique.

Bidriware Vases, Bidar

(Karnataka)

Handicraft Feature a zinc-copper alloy base with a distinctive black finish and fine

silver inlay

Kannadippaya Tribal Craft

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 135

132

UNESCO Heritage Sites

19 UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following properties included in the World Heritage List released by

UNESCO: [2024]

1. Shantiniketan
2. Rani ki Vav
3. Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas
4. Mahabodhi Temple Complex at Bodhgaya

How many of the above properties were included in 2023?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) Only three
- (d) All four

UNESCO Tangible Cultural Heritage Sites in India

Site Name & Year Location Historical Description & Features

Ajanta Caves (1983) Aurangabad, MH:

Waghora River.

2nd BC–5th AD; Vakataka patronage (Harishena): 29 Buddhist caves

(25 Viharas + 4 Chaityas) + Fresco paintings: focus on Jataka tales +

absence of blue color.

Ellora Caves (1983) Aurangabad, MH:

Charanadri hills.

5th–11th AD; Chalukya/Rashtrakuta patronage: 34 caves (12 Buddhist

+ 17 Brahmanical + 5 Jain) + Raavan ki Khai + Dashavatar temple +

Cave 16 (Kailasha temple): monolithic excavation + mural paintings of

human emotions.

Agra Fort (1983) Agra, UP: Yamuna

River.

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 136

133

Great Living Chola

Temples (1987/2004)

TN: Kaveri Delta. 11th–12th C; Imperial Cholas: Brihadisvara (Thanjavur) +

Gangaikondacholapuram + Airavateshvara (Darasuram): massive

Vimanas + fresco paintings + bronze casting.

Sanchi Buddhist

Monuments (1989)

MP: Buddhist zenith. 3rd BC–12th AD; Ashoka commissioned: Great Stupa + 4 ornate Toranas

(Buddhist life stories) + Ashokan Pillar: oldest stone structures.

Humayun's Tomb

(1993)

Delhi: Bega Begum. 1570 AD; Mughal garden-tomb precursor to Taj: Persian influence +

Charbagh layout + double dome architecture.

Qutub Minar &

Monuments (1993)

Delhi: Mehrauli

complex.

13th C; Slave dynasty: Qutub Minar + Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque +

Mehrauli Iron Pillar (rust-resistant Gupta metallurgy).

Mountain Railways

(1999/05/08)

WB, TN, HP:

Engineering marvels.

Darjeeling Himalayan (1881) + Nilgiri Mountain (1905) + Kalka-

Shimla (1903): British colonial infrastructure in difficult terrain.

Mahabodhi Temple

Complex (2002)

Bodh Gaya, Bihar:

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 137

134

Moidams – Ahom

Dynasty (2024)

Assam: Tai-Ahom

Kingdom.

13th–19th C; Charaideo: 90+ pyramid-like royal burial mounds + brick chambers + Tai ritual architecture.

Maratha Military

Landscapes (2025)

Maharashtra: Maratha

Empire.

17th–19th C; 12 forts cluster (Salher, Shivneri, Rajgad, Torna):

Strategic hill forts + water systems + military architecture network.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Which one of the following was the latest inclusion in the Intangible Cultural Heritage

List of UNESCO? [2024]

(a) Chhau dance

(b) Durga Puja

(c) Garba dance

(d) Kumbh Mela

2. With reference to Manipuri Sankirtana, consider the following statements:
[2017]

1. It is a song and dance performance.

2. Cymbals are the only musical instruments used in the performance.

3. It is performed to narrate the life and deeds of Lord Krishna.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1, 2 and 3

(b) 1 and 3 only

(c) 2 and 3 only

(d) 1 only

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History – Part 138

135

Sankirtana (2013) Manipur: Ritual

Singing.

Ritual drumming/singing/dancing: Vaishnavite themes (Lord Krishna life): marks religious occasions and lifecycle events.

Brass/Copper Craft

(2014)

Punjab: Thathera

community.

Utensil making in Jandiala Guru: traditional heating/hammering techniques: unique craft passed through generations.

Yoga (2016) Pan-India: Discipline. Physical/mental/spiritual practice: poses + meditation + chanting:

traditionally taught via Guru-Shishya parampara.

Nowrouz (2016) Pan-India: Persian

New Year.

Parsi/Zoroastrian spring festival: symbolizes the renewal of nature and hope.

Kumbh Mela (2017) 4 River Sites:

Pilgrimage.

Mass pilgrimage every 12 years; Ardh Kumbh every 6 years (Prayagraj (Ganga+Yamuna), Haridwar(Ganga), Nashik(Godavari), Ujjain(Shipra)): bathing in sacred rivers to wash sins.

Durga Puja (2021) West Bengal:

Kumartuli artisans

Annual October festival: 5-day clay goddess immersion + eco-friendly idols + grand temporary art installations.

Garba of Gujarat

(2023)

Gujarat: Navratri circle

Ancient and Medieval History

Ancient and Medieval History â€¢ Part 139

Page 139